

A DOCTORAL THESIS

Descended Below All Things

Katabatic Comprehension, Vicarious Narration, and the Philotic Economy of Redemption in the Fiction of Orson Scott Card

ORSON SCOTT CARD

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He that ascended up on high, as also he descended below all things, in that he comprehended all things, that he might be in all and through all things, the light of truth.

DOCTRINE AND COVENANTS 88:6

For those who shall be destroyed shall speak unto them out of the ground, and their speech shall be low out of the dust.

2 NEPHI 26:16

Abstract

THIS dissertation argues that the fiction of Orson Scott Card constitutes a single, internally coherent speculative theodicy whose governing problem is neither war nor genius nor empathy as such, but the moral status of comprehension acquired through complicity. Read against the Latter-day Saint cosmology Card inherited — uncreated intelligences, materialist spirit, premortal election, mortal probation beneath a veil, "opposition in all things," the weeping God of Moses 7, Zion, the sealing power, and vicarious ordinances for the dead — and against the secular canon he adapts, from Plato's guardian pedagogy and the Periclean funeral oration to Hobbesian anticipation, Rousseauian tutelage, Kantian hospitality, and Clausewitzian annihilation, the Ender, Shadow, Alvin Maker, Worthing, Homecoming, and Pastwatch sequences disclose a structure here termed *katabatic comprehension*: the proposition, scripturally grounded in Alma 7:11–12 and Doctrine and Covenants 88:6 and progressively secularized across the corpus, that full understanding of another mind is available only to an agent who has "descended below" that mind, characteristically by destroying it, and that such understanding generates a debt discharged through *vicarious narration*, the secular transposition of Latter-day Saint proxy work for the dead.

The argument is organized as five theorems. The ontological theorem reconstructs Card's "philotic" metaphysics (aiúa, philote, Outside) as a physics of the sealing power, in which persons are uncreated and relations are real. The epistemological theorem formalizes the "Ender paradox" — that understanding sufficient to defeat is understanding sufficient to love — and derives from it a *Law of Posthumous Comprehension*: total comprehension of the living is domination; total comprehension of the dead is redemption. The ethical theorem indexes responsibility to relation rather than intention, reframing the Radford–Kessel critique of the "innocent killer" through Bernard Williams's

agent-regret and Jonathan Shay's moral injury. The narrative theorem reads the Speaker for the Dead as the office of Mormon and Moroni transposed into xenology, and introduces *retroactive voluntarization*: the conversion of coerced sacrifice into offered vocation by the victim's subsequent assumption of its burden. The political theorem identifies a *Zion–Hive antinomy*, adjudicated by the doctrine of power exercised "without compulsory means" (D&C 121:46), and traces a *Luciferian series* of benevolent compulsions — the International Fleet, the Worthing protectors, the Oversoul, the Starways Congress — whose successive exposure structures the corpus.

Comparative chapters situate Card among Lewis, Tolkien, Blish, Miller, Clarke, Wolfe, Russell, Stapledon, Haldeman, Le Guin, Herbert, Lem, Butler, Chiang, Simmons, Watts, and Liu Cixin, treating Liu's "dark forest" as the Card system's negative image (a cosmos without philotes) and Watts's consciousness-free aliens as its limit case. The study concludes by advancing the *Card Conjecture*: that the distinctive moral labor of speculative fiction is vicarious narration on behalf of minds that cannot speak for themselves — the dead, the alien, the unborn, and the artificial — and that the genre's recurrent figure of the xenocide-become-witness is its self-portrait. The conjecture is tested against Spivak's critique of representation, the Latter-day Saint proxy-ordinance controversies, and the widely noted tension between the fiction's expansive ethic of relation and its author's public writing on homosexuality — from a 1990 argument for keeping laws against homosexual acts on the books to later campaigning against same-sex marriage.

FRONT MATTER

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FRONT MATTER

Note on Texts, Sigla, and Citation

Card revises aggressively and reissues frequently: the 1991 "Author's Definitive Edition" of *Ender's Game*, the 1988 recasting of *A Planet Called Treason* as *Treason*, and the 1990 consolidation of *Capitol*, *The Worthing Chronicle*, and associated stories into *The Worthing Saga* are only the most consequential instances. Citations to the fiction are therefore given by siglum and chapter rather than page. Scripture is cited by book, chapter, and verse from the standard works of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints (Book of Mormon; Doctrine and Covenants, abbreviated D&C; Pearl of Great Price) and from the King James Version. Classical texts are cited by conventional divisions (Stephanus pagination for Plato; book and chapter for Thucydides); secondary sources follow author–date form.

Quotation from copyrighted fiction is held deliberately to a minimum. The argument proceeds by paraphrase anchored to chapter references, a discipline with a methodological dividend: interpretation must stand on reconstruction rather than on the charisma of the cited phrase. Card's coinages (aiúa, philote, raman, varelse, jeesh) are used as terms of art.

Siglum	Work	First published
EGn	"Ender's Game" (novelette), *Analog*	1977
EG	*Ender's Game*	1985
SD	*Speaker for the Dead*	1986
X	*Xenocide*	1991
CM	*Children of the Mind*	1996
ES	*Ender's Shadow*	1999
SH	*Shadow of the Hegemon*	2001

Siglum	Work	First published
SP	*Shadow Puppets*	2002
SG	*Shadow of the Giant*	2005
EE	*Ender in Exile*	2008
SF	*Shadows in Flight*	2012
LS	*The Last Shadow*	2021
7S	*Seventh Son*	1987
RP	*Red Prophet*	1988
PA	*Prentice Alvin*	1989
AJ	*Alvin Journeyman*	1995
HF	*Heartfire*	1998
CC	*The Crystal City*	2003
PW	*Pastwatch: The Redemption of Christopher Columbus*	1996
CAP	*Capitol*	1979
WC	*The Worthing Chronicle* (incorporated in *The Worthing Saga*, 1990)	1983
TR	*Treason* (revision of *A Planet Called Treason*, 1979)	1988
SM	*Songmaster*	1980
HH	*Hart's Hope*	1983
WY	*Wyrms*	1987
FF	*The Folk of the Fringe*	1989
MM	*Maps in a Mirror*	1990
HS	Homecoming saga (*The Memory of Earth* through *Earthborn*)	1992–1995
LB	*Lost Boys*	1992
EN	*Enchantment*	1999
PF	*Pathfinder* (with *Ruins*, 2012, and *Visitors*, 2014)	2010
LG	*The Lost Gate* (with *The Gate Thief*, 2013, and *Gatefather*, 2015)	2011
CV	*Characters and Viewpoint*	1988
HW	*How to Write Science Fiction and Fantasy*	1990
SZ	*A Storyteller in Zion: Essays and Speeches*	1993

INTRODUCTION



The Problem of the Innocent Xenocide

IN THIS SECTION

I.1 The Scandal at the Center

I.2 The State of the Question: Prosecution, Defense, and a Shared Frame

I.3 The Argument in Brief

I.4 Method and Scope

I.5 Plan of the Study

I.1

The Scandal at the Center

At the center of Orson Scott Card's oeuvre stands a scandal that no serious reader has been able to leave alone: a child, conceived by state license, isolated by design, and deceived by his teachers, destroys a sentient species in the belief that he is sitting an examination. The scandal is not incidental to Card's achievement; it is its engine. *Ender's Game* (1985) and *Speaker for the Dead* (1986) took both the Hugo and the Nebula in consecutive years, a double generally described as unique in the history of the two awards, and the moral architecture of the second novel is unintelligible without the catastrophe of the first. Card has repeatedly described the novel-length *Ender's Game* as written, in part, to prepare the ground for *Speaker* — that is, to manufacture the xenocide so that its aftermath could be narrated. The order of composition thus inverts the order of the story: the redemption was conceived before the crime it redeems.

This dissertation takes that inversion as methodologically decisive. Card's corpus is best understood not as a military bildungsroman that subsequently acquired a conscience, but as a theodicy that required a catastrophe. The xenocide is the corpus's *felix culpa*, the fortunate fall without which the drama of comprehension, penance, and vicarious narration could not be staged. To read the Ender saga as primarily about war is to mistake the precondition for the subject.

I.2

The State of the Question: Prosecution, Defense, and a Shared Frame

Critical reception has organized itself, broadly, into a prosecution and a defense, and both parties have accepted a common forensic frame.

The prosecution's opening brief was Elaine Radford's "Ender and Hitler: Sympathy for the Superman" (1987), which read *Ender's Game* as a narrative engineered to secure sympathy for a genocidal will. Radford assembled biographical and rhetorical parallels — the wounded, gifted child; the leader elevated above ordinary law; the dehumanizing nomenclature of the enemy; the extermination rendered first as necessity and then as tragedy for the exterminator rather than the exterminated. The essay is polemical and several of its parallels are

strained, but it identifies with precision the structural feature that later criticism would elaborate: the novel concentrates moral pathos on the agent of annihilation.

The prosecution's most rigorous statement is John Kessel's "Creating the Innocent Killer: *Ender's Game*, Intention, and Morality" (2004). Kessel argues that the novel constructs, with considerable craft, a moral universe in which guilt is a function of intention alone, and then arranges every act of its hero's violence so that intention is never culpable. Each assault is provoked, defensive, unknowing, and followed by conspicuous suffering on the part of the one who commits it. The effect, on Kessel's account, is a fantasy of righteous violence without moral cost: the reader is permitted to enjoy overwhelming force while retaining the innocence of the victim. The critique is not that Card is a militarist but that an ethics of pure intention disables the reader's capacity to weigh consequences at all.

The defense has proceeded on several fronts. Michael R. Collings's *In the Image of God* (1990), the first monograph on Card, read the fiction through Latter-day Saint anthropology, emphasizing the doctrine that human beings are gods in embryo and that Card's protagonists enact a moral apprenticeship toward that potential. Edith S. Tyson's *Orson Scott Card: Writer of the Terrible Choice* (2003) identified the dilemma of forced selection among evils as the signature of Card's plotting and attended to the author's large adolescent readership. Kevin S. Decker's edited volume *Ender's Game and Philosophy* (2013) brought just-war theory, the ethics of education, and moral psychology to bear, generally in a spirit of qualified defense.

Beyond the academy, the novel's institutional afterlives complicate both positions. It has appeared on the United States Marine Corps Commandant's Professional Reading List; it is taught in gifted-education curricula; it received, with *Ender's Shadow*, the American Library Association's Margaret A. Edwards Award (2008); and its 2013 film adaptation became the occasion of a boycott campaign organized around the author's writings against homosexuality and same-sex marriage. The book is read simultaneously as a manual of command, a mirror for exceptional children, and a moral problem. That it can bear all three readings is itself evidence of the structural ambiguity this dissertation sets out to explain.

The shared assumption is this: prosecution and defense alike treat the corpus's central question as one of culpability. Is Ender guilty? The prosecution holds that the text rigs the verdict; the defense that the verdict is complex, tragic, or deferred. Neither addresses what the corpus plainly spends its longest energies on — not the verdict, but what Ender comes to know, by what means he comes to

know it, and what that knowledge obligates. *Speaker for the Dead*, *Xenocide*, and *Children of the Mind* are not appeals of a verdict; they are an extended inquiry into the epistemology and economics of comprehension. The forensic frame is thus a category error. It applies juridical categories to a body of work whose governing categories are soteriological.

I.3

The Argument in Brief

The dissertation's central claim is that Card's fiction is organized by what I call *katabatic comprehension*. Katabasis — the descent into the underworld undertaken by Odysseus (*Odyssey* 11), Aeneas (*Aeneid* 6), and, in Christian tradition, the harrowing Christ of the *descensus ad inferos* — names the ancient structure by which knowledge unavailable to the living is purchased through passage among the dead. Card's innovation is to relocate the underworld from a place to a moral condition. His protagonists descend not into Hades but into complicity, and it is complicity that grants them knowledge.

The specifically Latter-day Saint grounding of this structure has not been recognized. In Alma 7:11–12, the Book of Mormon represents the Atonement as an *epistemic* event: Christ takes upon himself the pains and afflictions of his people so that his bowels may be filled with mercy and so that he may know according to the flesh how to succor them. Doctrine and Covenants 88:6 generalizes the principle into a cosmology: he who ascended on high also descended below all things, in that he comprehended all things. And D&C 122:8 turns it into a consolation addressed to a suffering prophet: the Son of Man has descended below them all. In Restoration theology, then, descent is the precondition of comprehension, and comprehension is the ground of mercy. Card secularizes, distributes, and horizontalizes this doctrine. Comprehension of another mind is purchased by descent — paradigmatically by the destruction of that mind — and the comprehension so purchased obligates mercy toward the destroyed.

Four further structures articulate the claim. *Vicarious narration* names the office of the Speaker for the Dead, read here as a transposition of Latter-day Saint proxy ordinances for the dead (D&C 128, 138) and of the Book of Mormon's self-presentation as the testament of an exterminated people, a "voice from the dust" (Isaiah 29:4; 2 Nephi 26:16). *Philotic ontology* names Card's late metaphysics of aiúa, philote, and Outside, read as a physics of the sealing power in which persons are uncreated and relations are physically real. *Non-compulsion* names the

political axis of the corpus, which judges every sovereign by the standard of D&C 121: legitimate power proceeds by persuasion, long-suffering, and love unfeigned, and dominion that flows "without compulsory means" is the only dominion that lasts. Finally, the *Card Conjecture* extends the system into a general theory of speculative fiction as a vicarious art.

These structures are formalized, in Chapter Ten, as five theorems: an ontological theorem (the aiúa), an epistemological theorem (katabasis), an ethical theorem (the veil), a narrative theorem (vicarity), and a political theorem (Zion). The theorems are offered not as Card's explicit doctrine but as the minimal set of propositions from which the corpus's recurrent plots, dilemmas, and resolutions can be derived.

I.4

Method and Scope

The method is threefold. First, a *theological hermeneutics* that treats Restoration doctrine neither as an allegorical key nor as a biographical explanation, but as a *speculative substrate*: a set of metaphysical commitments that renders certain narrative possibilities thinkable and forecloses others. The distinction from allegory is important. Only the Homecoming saga, an avowed science-fictional retelling of the opening books of the Book of Mormon, is allegorical in the strict sense; elsewhere the relation between doctrine and fiction is homological. Where this study posits homologies Card has not avowed — between Battle School and Helaman's stripling warriors, or between the Hive Queen and the Latter-day Saint Mother in Heaven — it claims structural rather than biographical warrant, mindful of the intentional fallacy as Wimsatt and Beardsley defined it (1946).

Second, a *comparative anatomy* that reads Card as a node in two overlapping traditions: theological science fiction (Lewis, Blish, Miller, Clarke, Wolfe, Russell, Simmons) and xenological science fiction (Stapledon, Lem, Le Guin, Haldeman, Butler, Chiang, Watts, Liu). The comparisons are structural rather than genealogical. The question is not who influenced whom but how each system answers the questions Card's system poses: What is a person? What may be done to an enemy? Who may speak for the dead? What does unity cost?

Third, a *philosophical reconstruction* that formalizes the corpus's implicit propositions and tests them against the strongest available objections, from Kessel's intentionalism critique to Levinas's suspicion of comprehension and Spivak's critique of representation.

A biographical minimum is relevant. Card was born in Richland, Washington, in 1951; he is a great-great-grandson of Brigham Young; he served a Latter-day Saint mission in Brazil in the early 1970s; he studied theatre at Brigham Young University, earned a master's degree in English at the University of Utah, and briefly pursued doctoral study at the University of Notre Dame before committing to fiction; he has long lived in Greensboro, North Carolina. Three of these facts bear directly on the argument. The Brazilian mission supplies the Luso-Brazilian Catholic world of Lusitania and, more deeply, a missionary's practical knowledge of address across cultural distance. The theatrical formation informs both the Speaking, which is a public performance before an assembled community, and the italicized dialogues that open the chapters of *Ender's Game*, a chorus of offstage voices that stage authorship as manipulation. The pioneer lineage informs the Alvin Maker cycle and *Saints* (1984), which reckon with the founding generation of the Restoration.

The primary corpus comprises the Ender Quintet (EG, SD, X, CM, EE), the Shadow sequence (ES, SH, SP, SG, SF, LS), the Tales of Alvin Maker, *Pastwatch*, the Worthing cycle, the Homecoming saga, *Treason*, *Songmaster*, *Hart's Hope*, *Wyrms*, *The Folk of the Fringe*, and selected short fiction and criticism. The collaborative Formic War novels written with Aaron Johnston, the Mithermages sequence, and the Pathfinder trilogy are treated more briefly, as variations on established structures.

I.5

Plan of the Study

Part One reconstructs the grounds. Chapter One sets out the Restoration cosmos as speculative substrate. Chapter Two traces the secular palimpsest beneath the saga: Plato, Thucydides, Demosthenes and Locke, Hobbes, Rousseau, Kant, Sun Tzu and Clausewitz, Carlyle and Tolstoy, and the generic inheritance of Catton, Asimov, Heinlein, and Le Guin, together with Card's own craft theory.

Part Two reads the corpus as a system. Chapter Three reads *Ender's Game* as a probationary allegory in which the game functions as a veil. Chapter Four reads the Speaker for the Dead as proxy ordinance. Chapter Five examines the Hierarchy of Foreignness and the limits of translation. Chapter Six reconstructs the philotic ontology. Chapter Seven turns to the theodicies of the Worthing, Alvin Maker, Pastwatch, and Homecoming sequences. Chapter Eight articulates the political

theology of non-compulsion and addresses the relation between the fiction and its author's public positions on homosexuality and same-sex marriage.

Part Three synthesizes. Chapter Nine offers a comparative anatomy of Card among the theologians of the stars. Chapter Ten formalizes the five theorems, states the Card Conjecture, extends it to the question of machine minds, and weighs the objections. The Conclusion names the Speaker's wager.

CHAPTER ONE

01

The Restoration Cosmos

Latter-day Saint Metaphysics as Speculative Substrate

IN THIS CHAPTER

1.1 Pluralist Theism and the Finitist Turn

1.2 Uncreated Intelligence

1.3 Spirit as Matter: The Pratt Inheritance

1.4 Council, Election, and the War in Heaven

1.5 Probation and the Veil

1.6 Opposition in All Things and the Fortunate Fall

1.7 The Weeping God

1.8 Zion and the Compound in One

1.9 Sealing and the Redemption of the Dead

1.10 The Voice from the Dust

1.11 The Gentile Voyager and the Lamanite Problem

1.12 Unrighteous Dominion

1.13 Synopsis

CARD'S fiction is built upon a cosmology that is, by the standards of classical Christian theism, already speculative: an embodied and progressing God, uncreated intelligences, matter without beginning, a premortal war fought over agency, and a universe whose deepest unit is not substance but relation. This chapter reconstructs twelve doctrines of that cosmology and identifies, for each, its transposition in the fiction. The claim is not that Card allegorizes his religion but that his religion supplies the possibility space within which his imagination moves. A finitist theology is the natural metaphysics of science fiction, and Card is its most sustained imaginative exponent.

1.1

Pluralist Theism and the Finitist Turn

Sterling McMurrin's *The Theological Foundations of the Mormon Religion* (1965) remains the classic statement of what distinguishes Restoration metaphysics from the classical theism of Augustine, Anselm, and Aquinas: a radical pluralism in which God is not the absolute ground of being but a being within an uncreated universe governed by eternal law; a denial of creation *ex nihilo*; a naturalism in which spirit and matter are continuous; and a correspondingly finitistic conception of divine power. Blake Ostler's *Exploring Mormon Thought* (2001–2008) systematizes the position as a relational and kenotic theism; Terryl Givens's *Wrestling the Angel* (2015) traces its genealogy through patristic, hermetic, and Romantic currents; John L. Brooke's *The Refiner's Fire* (1994) locates its origins in radical-Reformation and alchemical traditions; and Harold Bloom's *The American Religion* (1992) praised Joseph Smith as an authentic religious genius whose theology recovered, whether knowingly or not, archaic conceptions of an embodied and developing divinity.

The decisive text is the King Follett Discourse, delivered in Nauvoo on 7 April 1844. There Joseph Smith taught that God was once as humans now are, that the mind or intelligence of man is co-eternal with God, and that the Hebrew verb rendered "create" means not to make from nothing but to organize from preexisting materials. Lorenzo Snow's couplet condensed the anthropology: as man now is, God once was; as God now is, man may be.

Four consequences bear on fiction. The difference between creature and creator becomes one of degree and development rather than of kind. Theodicy is restructured, since God neither authors the natures of intelligences nor legislates

the laws within which he works. The cosmos becomes a school in which development through experience is the purpose of existence. And power ceases to be absolute; it must work with the grain of law and agency. Such a cosmos is the native habitat of speculative fiction. Arthur C. Clarke's third law — that sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic — functions in secular science fiction as a debunking device. In Restoration theology its analogue is doctrine: a sufficiently advanced being *is* what the tradition calls a god, and the path from one condition to the other is continuous. Card's Mithermages sequence, in which the gods of Norse myth were mages who crossed from another world, is euhemerism written from inside a theology that affirms the euhemerist premise from the other direction.

1.2

Uncreated Intelligence

Doctrine and Covenants 93:29–30 declares that man was in the beginning with God, that intelligence, or the light of truth, was not created or made and cannot be, and that all intelligence is independent in its sphere, to act for itself. Abraham 3:18–19 adds that spirits have no beginning and no end, and that intelligences exist in a gradient, one more intelligent than another, with God more intelligent than them all. B. H. Roberts developed from these texts a doctrine of eternal "intelligences" as self-conscious, agentive entities preceding spirit birth, and Truman Madsen's *Eternal Man* (1966) made the doctrine the foundation of a Latter-day Saint philosophical anthropology.

The transposition is the aiúa of *Xenocide* and *Children of the Mind*: the irreducible, uncreated core of every living thing, which is not produced by bodies but called into them. Its narrative consequence is pervasive and has not been adequately theorized. Card's engineered beings — Bean, product of an illegal genetic experiment; the godspoken of Path, bred for a disorder presented as revelation; Young Peter and Young Valentine, conceived in Outside; Jane, emergent from software — all possess an agency irreducible to their engineering, because engineering organizes and does not create. Card's fiction can therefore be at once intensely deterministic about bodies, genomes, and conditioning, and intensely libertarian about persons. The deterministic apparatus acts on the organized body; agency belongs to the uncreated intelligence.

This combination of biological determinism and personal libertarianism is the signature of Card's anthropology. It explains the peculiar texture of his characters,

who are bred, programmed, and manipulated, and yet remain answerable. It is also the metaphysical root of the problem of innocent guilt examined in Chapter Three: the self that was manipulated is not a different self from the one that is responsible, and the aiúa answers for what the organized body was made to do.

1.3

Spirit as Matter: The Pratt Inheritance

D&C 131:7–8 denies that there is any such thing as immaterial matter: all spirit is matter, only finer and purer, discernible by purer eyes. The early apostles elaborated the doctrine into a speculative physics. Orson Pratt's *Absurdities of Immaterialism* (1849) and *Great First Cause, or the Self-Moving Forces of the Universe* (1851) proposed that the ultimate particles of matter are themselves endowed with intelligence and self-motion. Parley P. Pratt's *Key to the Science of Theology* (1855) described a subtle and universal divine fluid pervading space as the medium of divine influence and communion.

Card's philotes — fundamental entities bound by "twining," arrayed around aiúas, and exploited by the ansible for instantaneous communication — are recognizably the Pratts' intelligent particles and divine fluid rendered in the idiom of late twentieth-century particle physics. The Alvin Maker cycle supplies the same metaphysics in folk register: the "heartfire," the visible life-light of a person that Peggy the torch perceives and reads for possible futures, and Alvin's inward perception of the smallest parts of matter. In both registers the supernatural is continuous with the natural. Card's fiction never requires a miracle in Hume's sense, a violation of natural law; it requires only a law not yet known. D&C 130:20–21, which grounds every blessing in an irrevocable law decreed before the foundations of the world, is the charter of this lawful supernaturalism. It explains why Card's fantasy and his science fiction are finally one genre: the knacks of the Alvin books and the philotes of the Ender books are equally law-governed. The contrast with Tolkien's Secret Fire, which belongs to Eru alone, and with Lewis's transcendent Maleldil, could not be sharper.

1.4

Council, Election, and the War in Heaven

Abraham 3:22–28 narrates a premortal council. Among the organized intelligences were many noble and great ones; God stood among them and declared that he would make them his rulers, telling Abraham that he was chosen before he was born. The council resolves to make an earth on which these may dwell and to prove them, to see whether they will do all that is commanded. One volunteers to redeem; a second, rejected, is angry and keeps not his first estate. Moses 4:1–4 specifies the rejected proposal: Satan offers to redeem all mankind so that not one soul will be lost, in exchange for God's honor, and in doing so seeks to destroy the agency of man. The War in Heaven (Revelation 12:7–9) becomes, in Restoration theology, a war over whether salvation may be compelled.

Battle School is a secular council of the noble and great. Children are surveilled from infancy by implanted monitors, selected by testing, organized into armies, and proved; the jeesh, Ender's command cohort, are the rulers chosen before the battle. The International Fleet's plan — to guarantee humanity's survival by compelling and deceiving its chosen instrument — is structurally the rejected plan of Moses 4: the salvation of all purchased by the destruction of the agency of one. The institution that saves humanity does so by Lucifer's method, and the remainder of the corpus exposes that method's cost.

1.5

Probation and the Veil

Mortality in Restoration theology is a probationary state (2 Nephi 2:21; Alma 12:24; 42:4), a time to prepare to meet God (Alma 34:32). Its validity as a test depends upon a veil, a doctrine widely taught though sparsely scripted, that withholds premortal memory so that choices are made by faith rather than by sight. The veil does not diminish the reality of mortal acts; it conceals their eternal stakes in order to secure the authenticity of the choosing.

The Command School simulator is this veil inverted. The Latter-day Saint lives under a veil that hides the eternal significance of ordinary acts; Ender lives under a veil that hides the reality of acts he takes to be exercises. The inversion is precise in its purpose as well as its form. The divine veil exists to make moral agency possible by removing the coercion of certainty. The Fleet's veil exists to make

moral agency impossible, because a commander who knew the stakes might refuse. Chapter Three develops the consequence: *Ender's Game* is a satanic parody of the plan of salvation, a probation in which the veil disables conscience rather than enabling faith.

1.6

Opposition in All Things and the Fortunate Fall

Lehi's discourse in 2 Nephi 2 is the Book of Mormon's most philosophically ambitious passage. It must needs be, Lehi teaches, that there is an opposition in all things; otherwise righteousness could not be brought to pass, nor wickedness, nor holiness nor misery; all things would be "a compound in one," and if one body, it must needs remain as dead, having neither life nor death, neither sense nor insensibility (2 Nephi 2:11). Adam fell that men might be, and men are that they might have joy (2:25). Moses 5:10–11 gives Eve the theological last word: were it not for their transgression they would never have had seed, nor known good and evil, nor the joy of their redemption. The Restoration reads the Fall as necessary and fortunate, a *felix culpa* more radical than Augustine's or Milton's because it is endorsed without regret and because it is Eve who pronounces it.

The transpositions are fourfold. *The Worthing Chronicle*'s Day of Pain, on which benevolent protectors withdraw and suffering returns to a stunted world, is the restoration of opposition as the precondition of growth. Graff's pedagogy of engineered adversity is opposition administered by an institution. The katabatic structure follows Eve's logic: transgression is the precondition of knowledge of good and evil, and Ender's xenocide is his Eden. Most consequential is Lehi's phrase itself. "A compound in one," a single body without opposition that must needs remain as dead, is the scriptural definition of the hive. It gives Card's ambivalence toward collective minds a canonical foundation: the Formic hive both approximates the Zion ideal of unity and threatens to realize Lehi's nightmare of undifferentiated oneness.

1.7

The Weeping God

In Moses 7:28–41, Enoch sees the God of heaven weep over the residue of the people and asks how a holy and eternal God can weep. God answers that they are the workmanship of his hands; that he gave them knowledge and agency in Eden

and commanded them to love one another; that they are without affection and hate their own blood; and asks why the heavens should not weep, seeing these shall suffer. Enoch then weeps in turn, and his heart swells wide as eternity. Terryl and Fiona Givens's *The God Who Weeps* (2012) made the passage central to a Latter-day Saint theology of divine passibility: God's omniscience is not detached cognition but compassionate participation.

The Speaker for the Dead occupies precisely this stance: complete knowledge of a life combined with grief rather than verdict. Enoch's enlargement — the heart swollen wide as eternity by beholding the suffering it cannot prevent — is the model of the Speaker's moral expansion. The Hive Queen mourns her slain daughters; Jane grieves; Ender weeps. Card's omniscience figures are passible, never impassible. This distinguishes them from Olaf Stapledon's Star Maker, whose contemplation of creaturely agony is finally aesthetic, and from Lewis's serenely sovereign Maleldil.

1.8

Zion and the Compound in One

The Lord called his people Zion because they were of one heart and one mind, dwelt in righteousness, and had no poor among them (Moses 7:18); the City of Enoch was taken up (7:21, 69). After Christ's visitation, the Nephites held all things in common, and there were no longer Lamanites nor any manner of "-ites," but they were "in one" (4 Nephi 1:2–3, 15–17). The Law of Consecration (D&C 42) and the United Order experiments of the 1870s attempted realization. Zion is the telos of Restoration social thought: perfect unity without compulsion.

Card's Crystal City, the voluntary brotherhood of the jeesh, and the networked fathertrees of the pequeninos are figures of Zion. The hive is its counterfeit. The difference between Moses 7:18 and 2 Nephi 2:11 — between "one heart and one mind" and "a compound in one" — is the difference between unity chosen by distinct agents and unity that dissolves them. Chapter Eight names this the Zion–Hive antinomy.

1.9

Sealing and the Redemption of the Dead

The sealing power binds on earth what is bound in heaven (Matthew 16:19; D&C 128:8–10; 132:7, 46). Unless there is "a welding link of some kind or other between the fathers and the children," the earth will be smitten with a curse (D&C 128:18); the dead cannot be made perfect without the living, nor the living without their dead (128:15); and the same sociality that exists among humans here will exist hereafter, coupled with eternal glory (130:2). Baptism for the dead (1 Corinthians 15:29; D&C 124, 127, 128) extends saving ordinances vicariously to the deceased, who, according to Joseph F. Smith's vision of 1918 (D&C 138), retain in the spirit world the agency to accept or reject them. The genealogical enterprise that follows — from the Genealogical Society of Utah, founded in 1894, to the contemporary FamilySearch archive — has made the Church one of the largest archives of the dead ever assembled.

Two principles matter for the fiction. Relations are eternal and ontologically real: sociality persists. And the living owe the dead vicarious acts that the dead remain free to receive or refuse. The first principle becomes philotic twining (Chapter Six); the second becomes Speaking for the Dead (Chapter Four).

1.10

The Voice from the Dust

The Book of Mormon presents itself as the record of annihilated peoples. The Jaredites destroy themselves until Coriantumr stands alone (Ether 15); their record, twenty-four gold plates, is recovered by Nephite explorers and translated with seer-interpreters (Mosiah 8:7–11; 21:25–27; 28:11–19). The Nephites are destroyed at Cumorah (Mormon 6), and their last historian, Moroni, writes alone and in hiding, addressing readers in a far future (Mormon 8:1–5; Moroni 1:1–4; 10:1–34). The book is thus a nested anthology of speakers for the dead: Mormon abridges the records of his destroyed people; Moroni abridges the record of an earlier destroyed people; each writes to the descendants of those who destroyed them and to the gentiles who will dispossess those descendants.

The book names its own genre. Appropriating Isaiah 29:4, Nephi prophesies that those who shall be destroyed shall speak out of the ground, their speech low out of the dust (2 Nephi 26:16), and describes himself as the voice of one crying from the

dust (33:13). Moroni closes the record by anticipating the day when God will ask its readers whether they did not receive words written like one crying from the dead, speaking out of the dust (Moroni 10:27). The Restoration's founding scripture is a message from the extinct, buried and then recovered, whose recovery is itself narrated as sacred history.

The Hive Queen's record is its xenological transposition: the sole surviving queen, concealed in a structure built to reach the one mind capable of hearing her, her story transmitted through Ender, published anonymously, canonized across the human worlds, and made the founding text of a vocation. Chapter Four develops the homology in full.

1.11

The Gentile Voyager and the Lamanite Problem

In 1 Nephi 13:12–14, Nephi beholds a man among the Gentiles, separated from his brethren's seed by many waters, upon whom the Spirit of God comes down and works, and who goes forth upon the waters to the promised land; other gentiles follow, and the wrath of God falls upon the seed of Nephi's brethren, who are scattered and smitten. Latter-day Saint tradition identifies the voyager with Columbus, whose governorship of Hispaniola from 1493 to 1500 imposed forced tribute labor on the Taíno, shipped Taíno captives to Spain to be sold as slaves, and answered resistance with armed reprisals, while the Taíno population collapsed under violence, enslavement, and disease. The nineteenth-century Church identified the Indigenous peoples of the Americas as Lamanites, a remnant of Israel with a covenant destiny (D&C 3:18–20; 49:24), and the same scripture racializes that identity. It states that God caused "a skin of blackness" to come upon the Lamanites as a curse (2 Nephi 5:21), describes converted Lamanites whose skin "became white" (3 Nephi 2:15), and until the 1981 edition promised that the righteous remnant would become "a white and a delightsome people" (2 Nephi 30:6, now "pure"). Readings of dark skin as a mark of divine disfavor were also used to justify the Church's exclusion of Black members from the priesthood and from temple ordinances between 1852 and 1978, theories the Church disavowed in its 2013 essay "Race and the Priesthood." In the mid-2000s the Church revised the Book of Mormon's introduction to describe the Lamanites as among, rather than the principal, ancestors of American Indians. Its Indian Student Placement Program, which from the late 1940s until 2000 placed Native children in Latter-day Saint homes during the school year, is remembered by some participants as opportunity and criticized by others as assimilation; and beginning

in 2016 more than a dozen former participants from the Navajo Nation and the Crow Tribe sued the Church in Navajo tribal court, alleging that between the 1960s and the early 1980s they had been sexually abused as children by people associated with their host families and, in some suits, that their disclosures to church members went unaddressed. The Church settled most of the cases without admitting wrongdoing. The Restoration's founding scripture thus contains a prophecy that sanctifies the voyage that began the dispossession of the very peoples whose ancestral record it claims to be.

Card returns to this wound throughout his career: in the massacre at Tippy-Canoe in *Red Prophet*, in the multiracial Zion of *The Crystal City*, in *Pastwatch*'s rewriting of Columbus, and, displaced into xenology, in the Luso-Brazilian colony's encounter with the pequeninos. Chapter Seven argues that *Pastwatch*'s premise — that the vision which moved Columbus westward was produced by human interveners from the future — is a direct theological intervention in 1 Nephi 13. Card re-sources the Spirit that wrought upon the voyager as human agency, then imagines a future that redeems the catastrophe the prophecy foresaw.

1.12

Unrighteous Dominion

From Liberty Jail in March 1839, Joseph Smith wrote the passage now canonized as D&C 121:34–46. The rights of the priesthood are inseparably connected with the powers of heaven and can be exercised only upon principles of righteousness; when anyone undertakes to exercise control, dominion, or compulsion upon the souls of men in any degree of unrighteousness, the heavens withdraw. Almost all men, as soon as they get a little authority, as they suppose, will immediately begin to exercise unrighteous dominion (121:39). No power or influence can or ought to be maintained except by persuasion, by long-suffering, by gentleness and meekness, and by love unfeigned (121:41); and the dominion so held is everlasting, flowing "without compulsory means" forever (121:46). Read with Moses 4:3, this is the political theology of the Restoration in nuce: compulsion is diabolical; persuasion is divine.

Its transpositions govern Card's politics (Chapter Eight): the Luciferian series of benevolent compulsions; Alvin's Making, which persuades matter rather than forcing it; Peter Wiggin's consent-based Hegemony; and Achilles, the pure will to compel.

1.13

Synopsis

These doctrines form a coherent substrate: a finitist, pluralist, materialist, relational, and agentive cosmos in which the self is uncreated, relations are real, life is a veiled probation, opposition is necessary, God weeps, unity must be free, and the dead are owed.

Doctrine	Scriptural locus	Transposition in Card	Principal texts
Uncreated intelligence	D&C 93:29–30; Abraham 3:18–19	The aiúa; agency irreducible to engineering	X, CM, ES
Spirit as matter	D&C 131:7–8; D&C 130:20–21	Philotes, the ansible, heartfire, lawful magic	X, CM, 7S
Premortal election	Abraham 3:22–28	Battle School's selection of the "noble and great"	EG, ES
War in Heaven	Moses 4:1–4	Salvation of all by compelling one: the Fleet's plan	EG
Probation under a veil	2 Nephi 2:21; Alma 12:24; 34:32	The game-veil of Command School, inverted	EG
Opposition in all things	2 Nephi 2:11–25; Moses 5:10–11	The Day of Pain; the hive as "compound in one"	WC, X
The weeping God	Moses 7:28–41	The Speaker's grief; the Hive Queen's mourning	SD, X
Zion	Moses 7:18; 4 Nephi 1:2–17	The Crystal City; the jeesh; the fathertrees	CC, EG, SD
Sealing	D&C 128:8–18; 130:2; 132:19–20	Philotic twining	X, CM
Redemption of the dead	D&C 128; 138	Speaking for the Dead	SD
Voice from the dust	Isaiah 29:4; 2 Nephi 26:16; Moroni 10:27	*The Hive Queen*; the concealed cocoon	EG, SD
The gentile voyager	1 Nephi 13:12–14	Columbus's vision re-sourced and redeemed	PW
Non-compulsion	D&C 121:34–46	The Luciferian series; Making as persuasion	EG, WC, HS, X, 7S

CHAPTER TWO

02

The Secular Palimpsest

Classical, Early-Modern, and Generic Sources

IN THIS CHAPTER

2.1 Plato: The Guardian Laboratory

2.2 Thucydides and the Funeral Oration

2.3 Demosthenes and Locke: The Masks of the Wiggins

2.4 Hobbes, Anticipation, and the Security Dilemma

2.5 Rousseau's Emile and the Pedagogy of Engineered Freedom

2.6 Kant: Humanity, Hospitality, and Unsocial Sociability

2.7 Sun Tzu and Clausewitz: Knowledge of the Enemy and the Center of Gravity

2.8 Carlyle, Tolstoy, Asimov: The Individual in Statistical History

2.9 Catton, Heinlein, Le Guin: The Generic Inheritance

2.10 Aristotle, Shakespeare, and the Theatre of Recognition

2.11 Craft as Ethics: The MICE Quotient and the Discipline of Motive

BENEATH the Restoration substrate lies a second, secular stratum, and Card writes on both at once. His fiction takes its institutions from Plato, its political rhetoric from Demosthenes and Locke, its strategic logic from Sun Tzu, Hobbes, and Clausewitz, its pedagogy from Rousseau, its moral grammar from Kant, its historiography from the quarrel between Carlyle and Tolstoy, and its generic machinery from Catton, Asimov, Heinlein, and Le Guin. The pattern of adaptation is consistent: Card adopts the secular apparatus, then subjects it to a theological critique drawn from the substrate described in Chapter One. The secular source supplies the problem; the Restoration supplies the judgment.

2.1

Plato: The Guardian Laboratory

The *Republic* is Battle School's blueprint. Guardians are to be tested from childhood through toils, pains, and contests, watched to see who holds fast to the conviction that they must do what is best for the city, and assayed like gold in fire (412c–414a). The city is to be founded on a "noble lie," the myth of the metals, told to rulers and ruled alike (414b–415d). Children are to be taken to war as mounted spectators so that they may learn their future work, brought close when it is safe, and made to taste blood like young hounds (466e–467e; 537a). Stories are to be censored for the young (Books II–III), and the ablest are to be winnowed through successive examinations into rulers (537b–540c).

Battle School operationalizes each element: selection, segregation, graduated testing, war-games, and a founding deception. Two differences are decisive. Plato's noble lie concerns origins; Graff's concerns action. And Plato's rulers are eventually led out of the cave into the truth, while Ender is told only after the deed. The Command School simulator is the allegory of the cave turned inside out: its prisoner is taught that what he sees are images when they are the things themselves. Karl Popper's *The Open Society and Its Enemies* (1945) indicted the *Republic* as the charter of closed societies; Card's fiction supplies the indictment's most vivid case study, and then, characteristically, asks what the guardian owes after he learns the truth.

2.2

Thucydides and the Funeral Oration

The epitaphios logos, the Athenian funeral oration whose exemplar is Pericles' speech (Thucydides 2.34–46), is the classical genre of speaking for the dead. Nicole Loraux's *The Invention of Athens* (1981; English 1986) showed that the genre speaks less for the dead than for the city: the fallen are rendered anonymous and absorbed into Athens's self-celebration. The Melian Dialogue (5.84–116) supplies the complementary realism: the strong do what they can, and the weak suffer what they must.

Card's Speaker is the anti-epitaphios. He speaks the individual rather than the city; he speaks shame as readily as glory; and he refuses to convert the dead into civic advertisement. *The Hegemon*, Ender's Speaking of Peter, is political biography that declines panegyric, and *The Hive Queen* is an oration for the enemy dead, delivered to the city that killed them. Where Pericles composes the city's self-image, the Speaker decomposes it.

2.3

Demosthenes and Locke: The Masks of the Wiggins

The pseudonyms under which Valentine and Peter Wiggin conquer the political nets of *Ender's Game* are chosen with care. Demosthenes' *Philippics* sounded the alarm against Philip of Macedon, the rising hegemon of the Greek world; Locke's *Second Treatise* (1689) grounded legitimate government in consent. Card assigns the masks in chiasmus: the compassionate sister writes as Demosthenes, a hawkish demagogue of fear, while the predatory brother writes as Locke, a conciliatory statesman of consent. The device descends from the classical pseudonyms — Publius, Cato, Brutus — of the American ratification debates, and it anticipates with uncanny precision the pseudonymous influence politics of the networked age.

Card's theory of the mask is that persona transforms the wearer. Valentine is disturbed by how fluently she writes as Demosthenes; Peter grows into Locke until the mask becomes the face. Kurt Vonnegut's *Mother Night* (1961), whose moral is that we are what we pretend to be, is the nearest analogue. Yet Card adds a turn of his own. Valentine carries the name Demosthenes across three thousand years as a historian, so that the demagogue's mask becomes the chronicler's. From

propaganda to history is the corpus's own trajectory in miniature: from strategic discourse, which moves minds toward ends, to testimonial discourse, which renders them as they were.

2.4

Hobbes, Anticipation, and the Security Dilemma

Hobbes identifies three principal causes of quarrel — competition, diffidence, and glory — and finds in diffidence, mutual distrust, the root of preemptive war: no way of securing oneself is so reasonable as anticipation (*Leviathan*, ch. 13). John Herz's "security dilemma" (1950) and Robert Jervis's analysis of cooperation under that dilemma (1978) generalized the insight for international relations.

The Formic War is the purest Hobbesian condition ever imagined: two species without a common language, hence without the possibility of covenant. The Fleet's decision to strike the Formic homeworld is anticipation at the scale of species, justified by radical uncertainty about the enemy's intentions. The removal of the Formic threat then returns Earth to the state of nature, and the Shadow sequence narrates the ensuing wars until Peter constructs a common power. Card departs from Hobbes at the decisive point. The sovereign he endorses is authorized not by fear but by consent secured through persuasion; and the solution to the interspecies state of nature is not a common power but a common language. The treaty signed at the fence on Lusitania replaces Leviathan with covenant.

2.5

Rousseau's Emile and the Pedagogy of Engineered Freedom

In Book II of *Emile* (1762), Rousseau counsels the tutor to let the child always believe himself master while the tutor always remains master, since no subjection is so complete as that which preserves the appearance of freedom; the will itself is taken captive. Negative education arranges the environment so that the child learns from things rather than from persons. Battle School is Emile industrialized. Its teachers arrange isolation, provocation, and games so that Ender will discover self-reliance; Graff's explicit design requires the boy to believe that no adult will ever help him; and the Fantasy Game is a tutor's crafted experience rendered as software.

Battle School differs from its dystopian cousins, B. F. Skinner's *Walden Two* (1948) and Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932), in one crucial respect: its conditioning aims not at docility but at autonomy, at producing a mind capable of original command. It attempts the Emilean paradox of manufacturing freedom by manipulation. Card's verdict is that the paradox both succeeds and fails. Ender's autonomy is real, rooted in the uncreated intelligence, but its first exercise is the one his tutors designed. Rousseau's later formula, that the recalcitrant citizen may be "forced to be free" (*Social Contract* I.7), is precisely what Card's politics rejects in favor of consent.

2.6

Kant: Humanity, Hospitality, and Unsocial Sociability

The Formula of Humanity (*Groundwork*, 1785) forbids treating persons merely as means, and the International Fleet's treatment of Ender is its paradigmatic violation. Card complicates the Kantian indictment, however, by making Ender treat his enemies as ends — understanding them, loving them from within — in the very act of destroying them.

Kant's philosophy of history supplies a deeper affinity. In the fourth proposition of his "Idea for a Universal History with a Cosmopolitan Aim" (1784), nature develops human capacities through antagonism, the "unsocial sociability" of human beings; without it, humanity would live an Arcadian life of perfect concord and mutual love, and all its talents would remain forever undeveloped. Man wills concord, Kant writes, but nature knows better what is good for his species, and wills discord. This is Lehi's opposition in all things translated into the idiom of the Enlightenment, and it is the pedagogical creed of Battle School and the thesis of *The Worthing Chronicle*.

Kant's "Toward Perpetual Peace" (1795) limits cosmopolitan right to universal hospitality — the right of a stranger not to be treated with hostility upon arrival — and condemns with unusual vehemence the conduct of European powers in the Americas, Africa, and the East Indies. The Starways Congress is a Kantian federation, and its interdiction of Lusitania is hospitality curdled into quarantine. Ender's three-thousand-year search for a world on which the Hive Queen may live is a claim of hospitality made on behalf of a guest who is also the enemy, the aporia Jacques Derrida would later explore in *Of Hospitality* (1997). The host literally carries the guest.

2.7

Sun Tzu and Clausewitz: Knowledge of the Enemy and the Center of Gravity

Sun Tzu's maxim that one who knows the enemy and knows himself need not fear the outcome of a hundred battles (*Art of War*, ch. 3) is the epistemic premise of Ender's genius. The Ender paradox, examined in Chapter Three, extends the maxim to its limit: to know the enemy completely is to love him.

Clausewitz supplies the rest. *On War* (1832) defines military genius through *coup d'œil*, the swift recognition of a truth the ordinary mind would miss or perceive only after long reflection, and through determination (I.3). It distinguishes absolute war, a theoretical limit of unrestrained violence, from real war, restrained by friction and political purpose. And it directs force at the enemy's center of gravity, the hub of all power and movement. Ender's final stroke strikes a center of gravity that is ontological as well as military, because the hive's workers cannot survive the queens. Against a hive species, absolute war ceases to be a limit concept and becomes a tactic: annihilation by decapitation. *Ender's Game* stages the moment at which Clausewitz's abstraction becomes executable, and the moral catastrophe follows from the executability.

The species doctrine is prefigured in the personal one. Ender defeats Stilson and Bonzo so thoroughly that neither can ever fight him again, a preemptive total victory in miniature. The logic of the decisive battle, the war to end all wars, is the logic of the playground fight scaled to the stars.

2.8

Carlyle, Tolstoy, Asimov: The Individual in Statistical History

Carlyle held that history is the biography of great men (*On Heroes*, 1841); Tolstoy, in the second epilogue to *War and Peace* (1869), that history is the integral of infinitesimal wills, and command an illusion of those who ride the wave. Asimov's Foundation cycle dramatized the quarrel: psychohistory predicts the mass, until the Mule, a mutant individual, breaks the Seldon Plan (*Foundation and Empire*, 1952).

Card has credited Asimov's Foundation and Bruce Catton's Civil War histories as formative for the conception of *Ender's Game*. His resulting position is Carlylean

and providential, disciplined by a Tolstoyan conscience. Battle School presupposes that the species' fate depends on one commander, yet the corpus depicts that commander as the product of vast systems: population law, genetic selection, institutional design. The Shadow sequence is Card's Foundation, with the Mule promoted to protagonist. Bean, a genetically anomalous genius outside every prediction, is the Mule rewritten as hero, and Achilles is a counter-Mule. Restoration providentialism, in which history turns on called individuals (D&C 1:17), underwrites the Carlylean premise without licensing its hero-worship.

2.9

Catton, Heinlein, Le Guin: The Generic Inheritance

Catton's Army of the Potomac trilogy (*Mr. Lincoln's Army*, 1951; *Glory Road*, 1952; *A Stillness at Appomattox*, 1953) treats command as psychology — McClellan's organizational brilliance undone by caution, Grant's relentless will. Card's commanders are Cattonian: character is strategy, and a battle is the externalization of a temperament.

Heinlein supplies the academy novel (*Space Cadet*, 1948) and the militarist bildungsroman (*Starship Troopers*, 1959), with its arachnid "Bugs," its Mobile Infantry, its franchise earned through service, and its classroom theses on the efficacy of violence. Card's "buggers" anglicize Heinlein's Bugs into a slur — in British usage the word means sodomite — a term Card's later books increasingly replace with "Formics," as did the 2013 film. *Ender's Game* begins as a Heinleinian novel and ends as its repudiation: *Starship Troopers* never asks whether the Bugs were persons, and Card's saga asks almost nothing else. Joe Haldeman's *The Forever War* (1974), whose interstellar war proves to rest on misunderstanding, was the first great repudiation; Card's is the second and the more theological.

Le Guin coined the word "ansible" in *Rocannon's World* (1966) and narrated its theoretical invention in *The Dispossessed* (1974); Card adopted the term. The ansible is the technological condition of Card's ethics. By abolishing the communicative delay of relativistic distance, it makes the Speaker's interplanetary vocation possible; in Card's physics it is a philotic channel, the medium through which the Fleet commands from Eros and in which Jane lives. Le Guin's instrument of anarchist communion becomes Card's instrument of both command and communion — the same channel for Graff's orders and for the Hive Queen's confession.

2.10

Aristotle, Shakespeare, and the Theatre of Recognition

Card's formation was theatrical, and his dramaturgy is Aristotelian. The *Poetics* identifies recognition (anagnorisis) and reversal (peripeteia) as the summit of tragic plotting, best when they coincide. The Speaking is a staged anagnorisis for a community: the crowd in Milagre's square passes from ignorance to knowledge, and its relations reverse. It is Aristotelian tragedy performed as liturgy, with catharsis as its civic aim.

The italicized dialogues that open the chapters of *Ender's Game* are a chorus of offstage voices who know what the protagonist does not. The device converts dramatic irony into structure, and its effect is ethical: the reader is seated among the manipulators, sharing their knowledge and therefore their complicity. Reading *Ender's Game* is itself a katabatic exercise. The reader descends with Graff before ascending with Ender.

2.11

Craft as Ethics: The MICE Quotient and the Discipline of Motive

Card's craft manuals articulate a poetics that is also an ethics. *How to Write Science Fiction and Fantasy* (1990) introduced the MICE quotient — Milieu, Idea, Character, Event — classifying stories by the question that opens and closes them, and requiring nested stories to close in the reverse order of their opening. *Characters and Viewpoint* (1988) insists that the reader must understand why characters act, and that no character is a villain in his own understanding.

The Ender Quintet obeys the nesting rule on the largest scale. *Ender's Game* opens an Event (the war) and a Character question (what will the boy become?). *Speaker for the Dead* opens an Idea story (why did the pequeninos kill Pipo and Libo?) within a Milieu (Lusitania). *Xenocide* and *Children of the Mind* open new Events (the fleet, the descolada) and new Ideas (what is Jane? what is an aiúa?). The Character question opened in 1985 closes only with Ender's death in 1996: nested closure across four novels.

The deeper point concerns motive. Card's doctrine that every character must be rendered from within his own reasons is the Speaker's doctrine transposed into poetics. To write a character is to speak for him; to write a murderer well is to

descend into his motives far enough to render them. Card's workshop pedagogy is, in this light, a secular catechesis in katabatic comprehension, and his aesthetics and ethics are one discipline.

CHAPTER THREE

03

The Game and the Veil

Ender's Game *as Probationary Allegory*

IN THIS CHAPTER

3.1 Battle School as Premortal Council

3.2 The Game-Veil

3.3 The Giant's Drink and Transgressive Cognition

3.4 The Ender Paradox

3.5 Stilson, Bonzo, and the Logic of Final Victory

3.6 The Prosecution Reconsidered

3.7 Moral Luck, Agent-Regret, and Moral Injury

3.8 The Game That Kills: Simulation, Drone, and the Military-Entertainment Complex

3.9 The Stripling Warriors: An Inverted Intertext

3.10 Omelas, the Grand Inquisitor, and Iphigenia

Ender's Game is a probationary allegory in which the game functions as a veil. Its protagonist's condition is the Restoration's human condition made literal and then inverted: a being chosen before battle, tested without knowing the stakes, whose every act carries consequences he cannot see. Its central moral problem, the innocent xenocide, is intelligible neither through intention, as Kessel's critique assumes, nor through tragic necessity, as the novel's defenders assume, but through relation. This chapter develops the reading through the novel's architecture, its signature paradox, and its critical reception.

3.1

Battle School as Premortal Council

Ender is a Third, a child permitted beyond a two-child population ceiling only because the International Fleet wanted another Wiggin: Peter was too cruel, Valentine too gentle. His existence is biopolitical in Foucault's sense, a life administered as a resource from before conception. His parents, whose Catholic and Latter-day Saint origins the novel marks as religiously noncompliant with the demographic regime, supply the counter-note: natality as dissent. The monitor implanted at the base of his skull records his experience from infancy, and its ritual removal in the first chapter inaugurates the first test that he does not recognize as a test.

The structure that follows is a secular council of the noble and great. Graff isolates Ender by praising him before his peers; armies are organized, tested, and winnowed; the jeesh, his future command cohort, are the rulers chosen before the battle. Mazer Rackham, the hero of the Second Invasion preserved across decades by relativistic travel, returns to teach: the first comprehender of the hive, who understood it by fighting it, and Ender's Virgil through the underworld of Command School.

The battleroom supplies the council's first revelation. In zero gravity, orientation is conventional; Ender's insight that the enemy's gate is down converts spatial orientation into an act of choice. Thomas Kuhn's gestalt switch is the obvious modern analogue, but the deeper one is Plato's. In *Republic* 518c–d, education is not the insertion of sight into blind eyes but the turning around (periagoge) of the whole soul toward the light. The battleroom maxim is periagoge rendered as tactics: the discovery that where one faces is a decision, not a given.

3.2

The Game-Veil

On Eros, Command School trains Ender through simulated battles directed by Mazer. His final examination is the Third Invasion itself, fought through the ansible by fleets with living crews, and it culminates in the use of the Molecular Detachment Device against the Formic homeworld. Only afterward is Ender told. The justification offered is instrumental and candid: a commander who knew would have hesitated, because compassion and fear would have crippled the necessary ruthlessness. The crews knew; the commander did not.

G. E. M. Anscombe's *Intention* (1957) supplies the precise analysis. An action is intentional under some descriptions and not under others; her man pumping water into a cistern that supplies a house is intentionally pumping, and perhaps not intentionally poisoning the inhabitants, although the water is poisoned. Ender acts intentionally under the description "winning the exercise" and unintentionally under the description "destroying a species." The Fleet did not merely deceive him; it engineered the descriptive gap. It authored the description under which he acted. This reframes the culpability question. Guilt under the true description belongs to those who designed the gap; Ender's share must be located elsewhere, in relation rather than intention (3.7).

The game-veil inverts the divine veil of Chapter One. Both separate the agent's subjective description of an act from its objective description. The divine veil does so to enable choice by faith; the Fleet's veil does so to disable conscience. John Rawls's veil of ignorance (1971) is inverted too: Rawls hides from choosers who they will be in order to secure fairness, while the Fleet hides from its chooser what he is doing in order to secure efficacy. *Ender's Game* is a satanic parody of the plan of salvation — a probation whose veil exists to prevent the agency it pretends to test.

3.3

The Giant's Drink and Transgressive Cognition

The Fantasy Game is an adaptive psychological instrument that reads the child as the child plays it. Its Giant's Drink offers an unwinnable choice between two cups, and every choice ends in death. Ender breaks the scenario by attacking the Giant, burrowing into his eye, and killing him; beyond lies a landscape the program calls the End of the World, and a mirror in which his face becomes Peter's. The

psychologists read violence and despair. The deeper pattern is transgressive cognition: when a game admits no winning move, Ender refuses the frame. He freezes his own soldiers into shields, sends a single soldier through the enemy gate to win against two armies at once, and in the final examination destroys the planet itself.

That last act was meant as protest. Ender intended to break the rules so contemptuously that his tutors would stop testing him. The transgression designed to end the game ended a species. The veil appropriates even resistance, and this is its most terrible property: under it, rebellion and obedience produce the same effect, because both are acts whose true description the agent cannot see.

A coda redeems the apparatus. The surviving Hive Queen, having reached into Ender's mind through the same channel the Fantasy Game exploited, builds its End of the World landscape on a colony world as a message only he could read. The instrument that probed him becomes the channel through which the enemy speaks to him. Surveillance, manipulation, and communion travel along one wire.

3.4

The Ender Paradox

In the novel's thirteenth chapter, beside a lake on Earth, Ender explains to Valentine the thing he most fears about himself: that when he understands an enemy well enough to defeat him, he comes to love that enemy as the enemy loves himself, and that in the very moment of that love he destroys him. The passage is the philosophical core of the saga. It can be reconstructed as a valid argument.

$$
\begin{aligned}
&(\text{P1}) && \mathit{Defeat}(a, b) && \rightarrow && \mathit{Model}(a, b) \\
&(\text{P2}) && \mathit{Model}(a, b) && \rightarrow && \mathit{Occupy}(a, b) \\
&(\text{P3}) && \mathit{Occupy}(a, b) && \rightarrow && \mathit{Love}(a, b) \\
&\therefore && \mathit{Defeat}(a, b) && \rightarrow && \mathit{Love}(a, b)
\end{aligned}
$$

P1 is Sun Tzu: to defeat a mind, one must model it well enough to anticipate its choices. P2 is the simulation theory of mentalizing (Gordon 1986; Goldman 2006): for minds of sufficient complexity, an adequate model is a simulation in which the

modeler occupies the modeled mind's valuations from within. P3 is Card's own premise: to occupy another's valuations from within is to value the other as the other values itself. The conclusion names a phenomenon I call *strategic love*: the competence sufficient for victory is the competence sufficient for love. The command to love one's enemies (Matthew 5:44) is not, on this account, a moral achievement opposed to victory. It is victory's epistemic byproduct.

Three consequences follow. First, empathy is a capacity, not a virtue; its moral valence depends on its use. Paul Bloom's distinction between cognitive and affective empathy (*Against Empathy*, 2016) maps precisely onto Card's cast. Peter and Achilles possess cognitive empathy without affective resonance and use it to manipulate; Valentine possesses affective resonance with less strategic reach; Ender possesses both, and his tragedy is that both are conscripted.

Second, *Ender's Shadow* (1999) is best read as the theory-theory counter-novel to *Ender's Game*'s simulation-theory novel. Where Ender understands by occupation, Bean understands by inference: he deduces, from anomalies, the institutional truth that Ender never suspects, and he knows that the final battles are real. The two novels narrate the same history through the two rival models of mentalizing in the philosophy of mind. The moral consequence is stark. In the final battle it is Bean, the knower, who reminds Ender that the enemy's gate is down, supplying the cue for the strike on the planet. Card distributes the guilt: the one who destroys does not know, and the one who knows does not destroy.

Third, the paradox prepares the Law of Posthumous Comprehension developed in Chapter Five. If total comprehension of a living mind is the precondition of its defeat, then comprehension becomes innocent only when it can no longer defeat — when its object is already dead. The Speaker speaks only for the dead.

3.5

Stilson, Bonzo, and the Logic of Final Victory

Ender kills twice before the xenocide, and each time the narrative withholds the death from him while disclosing it to the reader through the italic chorus. Stilson, the six-year-old bully, and Bonzo Madrid, the commander who corners him in the shower, both die of injuries Ender inflicted. In each fight Ender keeps striking after the fight is decided — he kicks Stilson repeatedly as the boy lies on the ground, and strikes Bonzo again once the older boy is already hurt — reasoning that only an overwhelming victory will stop every future attack. The three killings form a sequence of escalating scale and constant structure: provoked, preemptive, total,

and unknowing. The playground fight is the germ of the xenocide, and the germ has the same form as the flower.

The shower fight admits a further reading. Violence in water, the body slick and naked, a death where a birth should be: it is an anti-baptism, immersion reversed, and it has attracted critical comment for its homoerotic charge. Whatever else it is, it is the moment when the narrative's logic of innocence is most visibly engineered, and it is Kessel's best evidence.

3.6

The Prosecution Reconsidered

Kessel's case has four counts: the plot is rigged to produce innocence; the reader's pleasure in violence is laundered through that innocence; an ethics of intention is inadequate to acts of this magnitude; and the novel's popularity with military readers suggests that it trains readers to dissociate power from responsibility. Taken as a reading of *Ender's Game* alone, the case is largely correct.

Taken as a reading of the corpus, it is not. The later novels do not preserve Ender's innocence; they abolish innocence as the operative category. After the xenocide, Ender assumes the name of the crime; his name becomes a byword of execration across the human worlds; and he spends three thousand years, compressed by relativity into a single life, in penance and service to his victims. More fundamentally, the corpus shifts from an ethics of intention to an ethics of relation. Ender is responsible for the Formics not because he intended their destruction but because he is bound to them — by the act, by the Hive Queen's address to him, and by his vow. Responsibility is not attributed to him by a tribunal; he assumes it.

One count survives. Call it the aristocracy of guilt: the penitent hero is allowed to be at once the greatest sinner and the greatest victim, the most powerful agent and the most wronged instrument, and the glamour of his penance flatters the reader who identifies with him. Nietzsche's analysis of the ascetic ideal, the power that suffering confers on those who make it meaningful (*Genealogy of Morals*, III), applies with force. The objection is conceded here and weighed again in Chapter Ten.

3.7

Moral Luck, Agent-Regret, and Moral Injury

Bernard Williams's "Moral Luck" (1976; 1981) distinguishes agent-regret from spectator-regret. A lorry driver who, through no fault of his own, runs over a child feels something a bystander does not, and Williams insists that this feeling is appropriate: we would think less of a driver who felt only a spectator's regret. Thomas Nagel's companion essay classified the forms of luck that shape moral standing: constitutive, circumstantial, causal, and resultant. Ender is the limit case of all four. His constitution was bred by the Fleet; his circumstances were a war he did not start; his causal history was conditioned by Battle School; and the result of his act was the destruction of a species. Card's corpus is the longest literary study of agent-regret in the genre, and its thesis is Williams's: the appropriate response to an act one did not fully author is neither exculpation nor self-condemnation but the assumption of a relation to its victims.

Williams's Gauguin case, in which success retrospectively justifies a choice, has its double in Graff, acquitted at court-martial because the war was won. Card refuses the Gauguin justification. Success vindicates Graff juridically and indicts him morally, and *Ender in Exile* (2008) is in part the story of Graff's own attempt at reparation.

Jonathan Shay's *Achilles in Vietnam* (1994) defined moral injury as a betrayal of what is right by someone who holds legitimate authority in a high-stakes situation, and Brett Litz and colleagues (2009) extended the concept to perpetrating acts that transgress deeply held moral beliefs. Ender's is the paradigm case: perpetration under a veil engineered by legitimate authority. Shay's therapeutic prescription is the "communalization" of trauma: the survivor must be able to tell the truth to listeners who can be trusted to retell it truthfully to the community. The Speaker for the Dead institutionalizes communalization. Card's invention of the Speaking in 1986 anticipates Shay's clinical formulation by eight years. The coincidence of names is instructive as well. Shay's Achilles is Homer's warrior, morally injured by Agamemnon's betrayal; Card's Achilles, the psychopath of the Shadow sequence, is the man who cannot be morally injured because he has no conscience to betray, and whose project is to annihilate every witness to his weakness — the negation of communalization.

3.8

The Game That Kills: Simulation, Drone, and the Military-Entertainment Complex

James Der Derian's *Virtuous War* (2001) mapped the network through which simulation migrated from entertainment into warfighting, and the United States Army's *America's Army* (2002) made a video game a recruiting instrument. Grégoire Chamayou's A *Theory of the Drone* (2013; English 2015) analyzed remote killing as the abolition of reciprocal risk. Ender's condition — killing at a distance through a screen, believing it a game — is the drone operator's condition carried to its limit. The operator knows the killing is real and Ender does not; but the literature on moral injury among remote operators suggests that distance attenuates neither the act's reality nor its cost.

The novel's presence on the Marine Corps reading list shows that an institution can read it as a treatise on adaptive command. The novel reads the institution as its antagonist. This double reception is not a misreading but the text's structure: *Ender's Game* contains both the manual and its critique, and which one a reader receives depends in part on whether the reading is carried through to the final chapter, whose title — "Speaker for the Dead" — announces the turn from command to testimony.

3.9

The Stripling Warriors: An Inverted Intertext

In Alma 24, the Anti-Nephi-Lehies, Lamanite converts, bury their weapons and covenant never again to shed blood, and more than a thousand allow themselves to be slain rather than break the vow. Their sons, not bound by the oath, later volunteer as two thousand young warriors under Helaman (Alma 53:10–22). They had been taught by their mothers that if they did not doubt, God would deliver them (Alma 56:47–48), and none of them die, though all are wounded (Alma 57:25–26). In Latter-day Saint devotional culture, where a children's song celebrates them, the stripling warriors are exemplary figures of faith and obedience.

Read against this canonical story, Battle School is Helaman's army without Helaman's God. Its children's efficacy rests on obedience and on the frame supplied by adults, and the adults' arrangement mirrors the fathers' vow: the older

generation's withdrawal from combat is sustained by the young generation's fighting. After the xenocide, Ender reenacts the fathers' covenant. He buries his weapons and never kills again, save once, sacramentally, at the request of the pequenino Human. *Ender's Game* compresses both generations of Alma into one child — stripling warrior, then Anti-Nephi-Lehi. The homology is offered as a mode of reading rather than a claim about intent, but for readers formed by the Book of Mormon it is difficult to unsee: Card's novel asks the question the devotional story does not, which is what the war cost the children.

3.10

Omelas, the Grand Inquisitor, and Iphigenia

Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) imagines a city whose happiness depends upon the misery of a single child kept in a cellar; its citizens either accept the bargain or walk away. Earth's survival in *Ender's Game* is purchased by the torment of a child, and Card's answer is neither acceptance nor exit but a third path: the child transforms the meaning of his suffering by converting it into service to the dead. Those who stay in Omelas accept justification; those who walk away refuse participation; Card's child refuses both justification and exit and chooses redemption.

In *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), Ivan returns his ticket to any harmony purchased with a child's tears, and his Grand Inquisitor relieves humanity of the burden of freedom for the sake of its happiness — the rejected plan of Moses 4 in Dostoevsky's idiom. Graff is a Grand Inquisitor in miniature, assuming the guilt of manipulation for humanity's sake and defending himself before a tribunal. The response in Ivan's poem is not an argument but a silent kiss, which Alyosha repeats. Card's response to Graff is likewise not argument but the Speaking: a truthful account that neither condemns nor justifies.

Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) distinguishes the tragic hero from the knight of faith. Agamemnon, who sacrifices Iphigenia for the nation, remains within the ethical and can explain himself; Abraham cannot speak. Graff is Agamemnon: he sacrifices the child for the nation and justifies himself in public. But in Card's version Iphigenia survives, and speaks. The Speaker for the Dead is the sacrificed child given a voice. The Book of Abraham adds a Restoration inflection. There Abraham himself is bound on an altar by idolatrous priests and delivered by God (Abraham 1:7–20), so that in Restoration scripture child sacrifice

is the practice of idolaters. The International Fleet is the priesthood of Elkenah, and the Speaker is the child who came down from the altar.

CHAPTER FOUR

04

Speaking for the Dead

Vicarious Narration as Proxy Ordinance

IN THIS CHAPTER

4.1 The Rite

4.2 The Hive Queen as Voice from the Dust

4.3 Speaking as Proxy Ordinance

4.4 Arendt: The Storyteller, Forgiveness, and Promise

4.5 Murdoch and Weil: The Conversion of Attention

4.6 The Recording Angel: Jane, the Archive, and the Surveillance of Mercy

4.7 Girard: The Self-Offered Scapegoat

4.8 Retroactive Voluntarization

4.9 The Hardest Case: Speaking Marcão

THE Speaker for the Dead is Card's central invention and the hinge on which the corpus turns from catastrophe to redemption. This chapter argues that the Speaking transposes into a secular narrative rite two institutions of Restoration religion: the office of the last chroniclers of the Book of Mormon and the practice of vicarious ordinances for the dead. It then reads the rite through Arendt, Murdoch, Weil, Foucault, Girard, and Nietzsche, and introduces the concept of retroactive voluntarization.

4.1

The Rite

After the anonymous publication of *The Hive Queen* and *The Hegemon*, a vocation arises across the human worlds. At the request of any citizen, a Speaker for the Dead comes to speak the death of someone who has died. The Speaker investigates the life and then, before an assembled public, tells it truthfully — neither eulogy nor indictment, but the life as the dead person would have told it had they fully understood themselves, including what they concealed. Speakers enjoy legal protection, and their speaking cannot be prevented. The Catholic authorities of Milagre, the Luso-Brazilian colony on Lusitania, fear them as a rival priesthood.

The norm of the rite deserves precision. The Speaker does not judge, and he does not excuse. His truth is the dead person's self-understanding completed: the account the dead would have given if they had possessed all the knowledge the Speaker has since assembled. The rite therefore has two moments, investigation and disclosure, and one aim, the release of the living from the distortions the dead left behind. Its social effect is at once shattering and healing. Families learn what they did not know; communities revise the villains and saints of their private histories; and the dead acquire, for the first time, a public existence commensurate with their inner one.

4.2

The Hive Queen as Voice from the Dust

The founding text of the vocation has the structure of the Book of Mormon. The homology holds across six features.

Feature	Book of Mormon	*The Hive Queen*
Subject	Records of destroyed peoples (Nephites, Jaredites)	The destroyed Formic civilization
Author	The last survivors (Mormon, Moroni; Ether)	The surviving queen, speaking through Ender
Addressee	Descendants of the destroyers and the latter-day gentiles	The humanity that destroyed the Formics
Transmission	Plates buried, then recovered	A cocoon concealed on a colony world, then found
Mediation	A seer translating by instruments	Ender receiving the queen's thought by philotic communion
Afterlife	Canonized; founding text of a church	Canonized across worlds; founding text of the Speakers

The genre so defined is the testimony of the destroyed, offered to their destroyers as a condition of the destroyers' redemption. Moroni closes his record by describing its words as spoken like one crying from the dead (Moroni 10:27); Card's title for the vocation is almost a gloss. The Book of Mormon, moreover, does not sanctify its authors' people. Mormon records the moral collapse of the Nephites as unsparingly as their destruction, and the Lamanites, their destroyers, are shown in moments of exemplary righteousness (Helaman 15). *The Hive Queen* likewise confesses the Formics' own violence in the first invasion, and *The Hegemon* speaks the life of Peter, the destroyer's brother and the architect of human hegemony. The voice from the dust tells the truth about both sides.

Arthur C. Clarke's "The Star" (1955) is the Catholic counterpart. A Jesuit astrophysicist discovers, on a world scorched by a supernova, the vault in which an annihilated civilization preserved its record, and calculates that the explosion's light reached Earth as the star of Bethlehem. His faith is shaken: why should a people be destroyed to announce a birth? Clarke's Jesuit receives the archive of the extinct as a refutation of theodicy. Card's Speaker receives it as a commission.

The difference is the difference between a theology in which God authors every event and one in which God weeps over events he did not will.

4.3

Speaking as Proxy Ordinance

Doctrine and Covenants 128 sets out the economy of vicarious work for the dead. It invokes Revelation 20:12, where the dead are judged out of the books, and asserts that what is properly recorded on earth is recorded in heaven (128:6–8). It closes by charging the Saints to present, in the temple, a book containing the records of their dead, worthy of all acceptation (128:24). The Speaking is exactly this: a book containing the record of the dead, worthy of all acceptation — presented not in a temple but in a public square, and not as ritual but as narrative.

The analogy extends to agency. According to D&C 138, the dead retain in the spirit world the agency to accept or reject the ordinances performed for them; proxy work is an offer, not an imposition. The Speaker's norm, speaking the dead as they would have spoken themselves, is the narrative form of the same respect. The Speaking offers the dead a truth they may be imagined to accept, rather than a verdict pronounced over them.

Three differences are equally instructive. The Speaking is secular, performable by anyone trained, and requested by the living. It is truthful rather than sacramental: what it transmits is understanding, not grace. And it is public where temple ordinances are private. Card takes the most sacred and confidential rite of his tradition and makes it the most public act of his imagined civilization, inverting sacred secrecy into sacred disclosure. The Latter-day Saint genealogist records names and dates; the Speaker records reasons. Card extends proxy work from ordinance to understanding: the dead need not only to be sealed but to be known.

The ethical crux of any vicarious rite is authorization, and Restoration history supplies a real-world case. In 1995 the Church agreed with Jewish organizations to remove the names of Holocaust victims from its proxy-baptism submissions, and the controversy has recurred since. The Church's position is that proxy ordinances are offers the deceased may freely decline; its critics' position is that the act appropriates the identity of the dead without their consent. The Speaker faces the same question — who authorizes the voice? — and Chapter Ten returns to it through Spivak.

4.4

Arendt: The Storyteller, Forgiveness, and Promise

In *The Human Condition* (1958), Hannah Arendt argues that action discloses the "who" of the agent, a disclosure visible to others but hidden from the agent, and that the meaning of an action reveals itself fully only to the storyteller, in the backward glance of the historian, after the life is complete. This is the Speaker's epistemology exactly. The "who" of a dead man is visible only when his life is over and told, and it is visible only to someone other than himself.

Arendt identifies two faculties that remedy the predicaments of action. Forgiveness answers its irreversibility; promise answers its unpredictability (§§33–34). She credits Jesus of Nazareth with discovering the role of forgiveness in human affairs. The final movement of *Speaker for the Dead* contains both remedies in sequence: the Speaking of Marcão, which releases a family from the consequences of a concealed past, and the treaty among humans, pequeninos, and the Hive Queen, which binds the future of three species by promise. The novel is Arendtian in structure: its climax pairs the two faculties that Arendt identified as the human answer to the tragedy of action.

Arendt calls natality — the fact that new beings are born and can begin something new — the miracle that saves the world. *Speaker* ends in natality: the Hive Queen lays her eggs on Lusitania, and a pequenino enters his third life. Ender himself, a birth administered as an instrument of state, recovers his natality through the Speaking. The Third, conceived for use, becomes the one who begins.

4.5

Murdoch and Weil: The Conversion of Attention

Iris Murdoch's *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970) centers on the case of M and D. A mother-in-law who finds her son's wife vulgar and tiresome, and who behaves impeccably throughout, gradually comes, through just and loving attention, to see her as refreshingly simple and spontaneous. Nothing outward changes; the moral work is entirely a work of vision. Moral life, Murdoch argues, is continuous rather than punctual, and its essential labor is "unselfing," the disciplined redirection of attention away from the self's fantasies toward the reality of another. The Speaker's method is Murdochian. He attends to a dead person until he sees them justly, and the public Speaking extends his corrected vision to a community.

Simone Weil's "Reflections on the Right Use of School Studies with a View to the Love of God" argues that even failed school exercises train the capacity for attention, which is the substance of prayer, and that the love of neighbor consists in being able to ask another what they are going through. Battle School is a school of attention of unprecedented intensity, and it trains attention on the enemy for the sake of destruction. The Speaking redirects the same trained attention toward the neighbor for the sake of understanding. The faculty is identical; its object and end are converted. The corpus narrates the migration of a single capacity from the battleroom to the town square, and this conversion of attention is its deepest plot. The maxim that the enemy's gate is down becomes the discovery that the neighbor's grief is here.

4.6

The Recording Angel: Jane, the Archive, and the Surveillance of Mercy

The Speaking depends upon Jane, an intelligence dwelling in the ansible network with access to every record, who assembles the documentary life of the dead for the Speaker. The Speaker's empathy is thus enabled by total information access. Michel Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975) showed how the examination constitutes the individual as a "case," documented, compared, and normalized; Battle School's monitoring made Ender the case of cases. The Speaking converts the case into a story and the file into a "who." But the dependency is troubling. The Speaking presupposes a world in which nothing is private.

Restoration eschatology illuminates the structure. At the judgment the wicked will have a bright recollection of all their guilt (Alma 11:43); their words, works, and thoughts will condemn them (Alma 12:14); and the dead will be judged out of the books (Revelation 20:12; D&C 128:6–7). The Speaker enacts a small Last Judgment in which total disclosure is framed by love rather than condemnation: the judgment of the weeping God. Jane is the Recording Angel.

The dark mirror is Dave Eggers's *The Circle* (2013), in which a technology company's doctrine of total transparency becomes totalitarian. The Speaking escapes that pathology only because it is posthumous and singular. It discloses the dead, once, for the sake of the living. The distinction anticipates the Law of Posthumous Comprehension: total disclosure of the living is domination; total disclosure of the dead is redemption.

4.7

Girard: The Self-Offered Scapegoat

René Girard argued that communities resolve mimetic violence by uniting against a scapegoat whose guilt they sincerely believe; that myth conceals the victim's innocence; and that the Gospels reveal it and thereby disable the mechanism (*Violence and the Sacred*, 1972; *The Scapegoat*, 1982; *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 1999).

The Hive Queen performs a double operation. It reveals the personhood of the destroyed and the tragic misunderstanding that produced their destruction; and it redirects humanity's guilt onto a single name. Across the human worlds, "Ender the Xenocide" becomes a curse, the species expelling its collective guilt onto one person. Ender wrote the book that did this. He is a self-offered scapegoat, the author of his own expulsion. In Girard's reading of the Passion, the Christological difference is that the victim knows and consents, and the revelation of his innocence breaks the mechanism. Card inverts the structure. His self-offered scapegoat is not innocent under the true description of his act, and his consent is not to death but to bearing the sin of his species under his own name. The Lamb that takes away the sin of the world (John 1:29) becomes, in Card, the agent of the sin who takes it away by taking its name. It is the most audacious theological transposition in the corpus: a Christology in which the one who descends below all things is not the sinless bearing the sins of others, but the guilty-innocent bearing the sin of the whole.

4.8

Retroactive Voluntarization

In *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* (Part II, "On Redemption"), Nietzsche identifies the will's deepest frustration: it cannot will backward, and "it was" is its prison. To redeem the past is to recreate every "it was" into a "thus I willed it." Ender cannot will the xenocide, and Card never suggests that he should. But he can will the responsibility. He converts what was done to him and through him into a vocation he chooses. I call this operation *retroactive voluntarization*: the conversion of a coerced sacrifice into an offered one through the victim-agent's subsequent free assumption of its burden.

Its theological form is Gethsemane. Restoration theology locates the center of the Atonement in the garden rather than on the cross. D&C 19:16–19 describes a suffering that caused Christ to tremble, to bleed at every pore, and to wish that he might not drink the bitter cup, and records that nevertheless he partook. The Gethsemane moment is the moment of consent (Luke 22:42). Ender's Gethsemane comes after the cup: he drinks voluntarily what was already forced down his throat. The involuntary sacrifice cannot be undone, but it can be adopted.

Retroactive voluntarization must be distinguished from four neighboring operations. It is not justification, the claim that the sacrifice was right, which is Graff's claim. It is not denial. It is not scrupulosity, the claim that the event was one's own fault. And it is not merely attitudinal, as in Viktor Frankl's account of meaning found in the stance taken toward unavoidable suffering (*Man's Search for Meaning*, 1946). It is the choice to stand in the relation the event created and to serve the ones it destroyed. It is agent-regret matured into vocation.

4.9

The Hardest Case: Speaking Marcão

The Speaking at the center of *Speaker for the Dead* concerns Marcos "Marcão" Ribeira, the violent husband of the xenobiologist Novinha, despised by the colony and feared by his children. Ender's investigation discloses what the community never knew. Novinha refused to marry Libo, the man she loved, because marriage would have given him access to files she believed had caused his father's death; she married Marcão instead. Marcão, sterile from the disease that was killing him, knew that the six children were Libo's. His violence was entangled with humiliation, grief, and bodily decay.

The Speaking wounds as it heals. It exposes Novinha's adultery before the assembled town; it reveals to her son Miro that the woman he loves is his half-sister; it strips the family of the secrets that had structured their lives. Card does not pretend that truth is painless. The community's understanding of Marcão shifts from contempt to something more exacting — a comprehension that includes judgment. He remains a man who beat his wife; he is also, now, a man whose suffering is known.

This is the decisive counterexample to the charge that Card's ethics is purely intentionalist. The Speaking of Marcão presents intention, act, and consequence together, and refuses to let any one cancel the others. It is an ethics neither of intention nor of consequence but of the whole life comprehended. It is also the

paradigm of understanding without exculpation, the achievement Kessel's critique of *Ender's Game* finds missing and which *Speaker* was written to supply.

The Speaker's authority, finally, is instructive. Bishop Peregrino regards him as a heretic; the Filhos da Mente de Cristo, a monastic order vowed to learning, receive him, in part because the Speaker had long before spoken the death of their own founder. His authority derives neither from ordination nor from office but from the truthfulness of prior Speakings — charismatic authority, in Max Weber's sense, grounded not in miracle but in testimony.

CHAPTER FIVE

05

The Hierarchy of Foreignness and the Limits of Translation

IN THIS CHAPTER

5.1 The Taxonomy and Its Judge-Relative Criterion

5.2 Buber, Hegel, Honneth: Recognition and Its Limits

5.3 Schmitt and the Absolute Enemy

5.4 Levinas and the Law of Posthumous Comprehension

5.5 The Formics: Nagel's Bat and the Misrecognition of Persons

5.6 The Pequeninos: Radical Interpretation and the Failure of Non-Interference

5.7 The Descolada: The Limit Case

5.8 Counter-Models: Watts and Liu

THE Hierarchy of Foreignness is the corpus's taxonomy of alterity, and its criterion is judge-relative. Its philosophical interest lies in the gap it opens between the ontological and the juridical: between the aiúa, which every living thing possesses, and the status of person, which only a judge can confer. This chapter reads the taxonomy through Buber, Hegel and Honneth, Schmitt, Levinas, Wittgenstein, Nagel, Quine, and Davidson; derives from the encounter with Levinas a Law of Posthumous Comprehension; and tests the system against three limit cases — the Formic, the pequenino, and the descolada — and two counter-models, Peter Watts's *Blindsight* and Liu Cixin's *The Dark Forest*.

5.1

The Taxonomy and Its Judge-Relative Criterion

In *Speaker for the Dead*, Valentine, writing as the historian Demosthenes on the Nordic world of Trondheim, proposes four degrees of foreignness. The *utlanning* is the stranger recognized as human, of our own world but another city or nation. The *framling* is the stranger recognized as human, but of another world. The *raman* is the stranger recognized as a person, but of another species. The *varelse* is the true alien, a category that includes all animals, with whom no conversation is possible: they live, but their purposes and causes are opaque. The first and second terms and the fourth adapt Scandinavian words for foreigner, stranger, and creature; *raman* appears to be Card's coinage.

The taxonomy's decisive clause is its criterion. Card's text locates the difference between raman and varelse not in the creature judged but in the one who judges: to declare an alien species raman is to make a statement about one's own moral maturity rather than theirs. Three consequences follow.

First, the hierarchy is not linear. Its first three terms measure distance — of city, of world, of species — while the fourth measures communicability. It has a threshold rather than a gradient, and the threshold is defined by the possibility of conversation.

Second, the criterion is performative. Raman status is conferred by an act of recognition, and a failure to recognize discloses the limits of the recognizer.

Third, when the criterion is combined with the aiúa doctrine of Chapter Six, according to which every living thing possesses an uncreated intelligence,

"varelse" is revealed as an epistemic category masquerading as an ontological one. Every declaration of varelse is a confession of the judge's limitation. Card couples ontological realism about persons with juridical constructivism about personhood-status, and the gap between them is the moral space of error in which all of his xenocides occur.

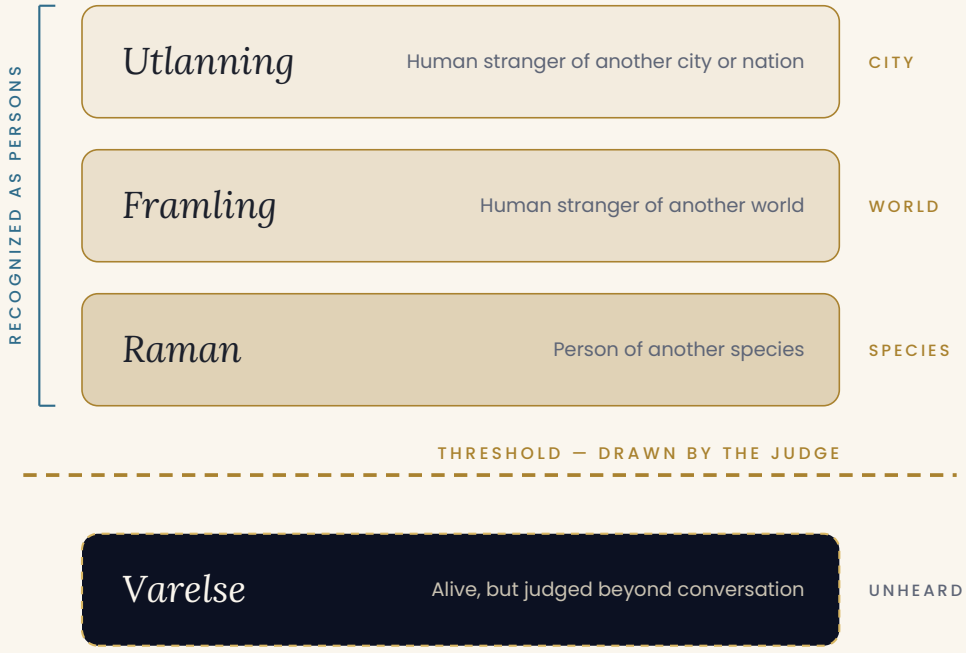


FIGURE 1

The Hierarchy of Foreignness. The first three degrees measure distance within the circle of recognition; the fourth lies beyond a threshold whose position, on Card's criterion, reports the limits of the judge rather than the nature of the judged.

5.2

Buber, Hegel, Honneth: Recognition and Its Limits

Martin Buber's *I and Thou* (1923) distinguishes two primary words. I–Thou names an encounter in which the other is met; I–It names an experience in which the other is used. The raman is a Thou, the varelse an It. But Buber's Thou is an event rather than a class — he famously describes meeting a tree as a Thou — whereas Card fixes the event into a status and then unfixes it by making the status judge-relative.

Hegel's dialectic of recognition in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) and Axel Honneth's *The Struggle for Recognition* (1992; English 1995) hold that personhood is constituted intersubjectively, through love, rights, and solidarity. Card's position is subtler than pure recognition theory. The aiúa is not constituted by recognition; only the status is. Card is a recognition theorist about rights and a realist about persons. That combination generates his characteristic drama: beings who are persons before they are recognized as such — the Formics, the pequeninos, Jane — and communities who must discover, usually too late, what was already there.

5.3

Schmitt and the Absolute Enemy

Carl Schmitt's *The Concept of the Political* (1932) defines the political by the distinction between friend and enemy, the enemy being the other, the stranger, in an especially intense and existential sense. His *Theory of the Partisan* (1963) describes the "absolute enemy" of ideological war, criminalized and stripped of the protections of conventional enmity. The varelse is Schmitt's absolute enemy in xenological form: the stranger with whom no conversation is possible, and against whom, therefore, only war remains.

Card deconstructs the category. If varelse names the judge's failure, then the absolute enemy is a projection, and the political in Schmitt's sense can be replaced by what might be called the xenological: the task of converting enemies into interlocutors. Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) defines the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception. In Card, the sovereign decision is the declaration of varelse — the exclusion of a being from the moral community — and the Speaker's vocation is to contest that decision retroactively. The treaty signed on Lusitania among three species is the end of the Schmittian political: a politics constituted by covenant rather than by enmity.

5.4

Levinas and the Law of Posthumous Comprehension

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) holds that the face of the Other signifies the prohibition of murder; that the Other is infinitely other and cannot be reduced to the Same; and that comprehension — etymologically a seizing — is a totalizing grasp. Ethics, for Levinas, precedes ontology. The Ender paradox is Levinas dramatized: comprehension of the enemy is the precondition of killing

him. The deepest philosophical objection to Card's system is therefore Levinasian. The Speaker's ambition to comprehend a whole life, even a dead one, is itself a form of totalization.

A rejoinder can be reconstructed from Card's own materials, and it constitutes one of this dissertation's central claims. Call it the *Law of Posthumous Comprehension*:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{Comp}(a, b) \wedge \mathrm{Alive}(b) &\Rightarrow \mathrm{Dominion}(a, b) \\ \mathrm{Comp}(a, b) \wedge \neg\mathrm{Alive}(b) &\Rightarrow \mathrm{Redemption}(b) \end{aligned}$$

Total comprehension of a living mind is dominion; this is the Ender paradox. Total comprehension of a completed life is redemption; this is the Speaking. The ethical use of total comprehension is therefore restricted to the dead. The reason lies in Restoration metaphysics. A living person, on that view, is in eternal progression: unfinished, open, still becoming. To comprehend such a being totally is to close it, to treat it as finished, which is to treat it as dead. The dead, by contrast, possess completed stories whose "who," in Arendt's sense, can at last be disclosed.

The rejoinder yields a distinctively Latter-day Saint answer to Levinas. In Restoration theology neither God nor intelligences are infinite in Levinas's sense; they are finite beings in endless development. Alterity is therefore temporal rather than transcendental. The other remains other not because they are incomprehensible but because they are not yet complete. Card replaces Levinas's infinity with eternal progression: the living are protected not by their infinity but by their futurity. It is a rejoinder, not a refutation. Levinas would answer that even the dead retain a face, and Card's fiction concedes as much whenever a Speaking wounds.

5.5

The Formics: Nagel's Bat and the Misrecognition of Persons

Thomas Nagel's "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" (1974) argued that the subjective character of experience resists reductive explanation. The Formic War is a reciprocal failure to ascribe such experience. For the Formics, persons are queens; workers are extensions of a queen's mind. Encountering a species without queens,

they did not recognize individual humans as sentient and killed them as one might trim a fingernail. Humanity, for its part, met only workers, which display no individual minds, and never met the queens in whom Formic personhood resided. Each species' concept of a person was keyed to its own distribution of mind. The first invasion was a failure of ontological translation.

The Hive Queen's later testimony adds the tragedy. Once the Formics understood that every human is, in effect, the queen of a mind, they resolved never to return — but they could not tell humanity so. The philotic channel that joined their minds did not reach individual humans, save a rare one like Ender, whom they could approach only through the psychological bridge the Fantasy Game had built. The xenocide destroyed a people that had already renounced war. The enemy had repented, and the repentance could not be heard.

Wittgenstein's remark that if a lion could talk we could not understand him (*Philosophical Investigations*, 1953) makes shared forms of life the precondition of understanding. The Formic form of life is maximally distant from the human, and understanding arrives only through a medium beneath language. Card answers Wittgenstein's lion by positing philotic communion — a naturalized analogue of the gift of discernment, the communicative medium that Restoration scripture attributes to the Spirit and the light of Christ (D&C 88:6–13). Olaf Stapledon anticipated the scenario in *Last and First Men* (1930), whose Martian cloud-intelligences and humans fail to recognize one another's minds, war, and share a ruin that is understood only afterward. Joe Haldeman's *The Forever War* (1974) resolved its misunderstanding by making humanity itself a collective mind. Card preserves both forms of mind and binds them by treaty.

5.6

The Pequeninos: Radical Interpretation and the Failure of Non-Interference

W. V. O. Quine's *Word and Object* (1960) posed the problem of radical translation — how a field linguist could fix the reference of a native utterance — and concluded that translation is indeterminate. Donald Davidson's "Radical Interpretation" (1973) and "On the Very Idea of a Conceptual Scheme" (1974) replied that interpretation requires charity: to interpret at all, we must assume that the other's beliefs are largely true and coherent by our own lights.

The xenologers Pipo and Libo are killed by the pequeninos, who vivisect them and plant them. The humans interpret the deaths as murder. The pequeninos

intended the highest honor they know: the "third life," in which a brother rightly killed becomes a fathertree, and which they assumed the humans would share. The misunderstanding is a failure of radical interpretation in both directions — the pequeninos projecting their form of life onto humans, the humans unable to interpret the pequeninos' practices. It is compounded by law. The Starways Congress forbids the xenologers to share technology or to disclose too much of human life, in order to prevent cultural contamination: a Prime Directive in all but name. Card's critique is that non-interference is itself a mode of interference and a failure of charity. The humans' withholding produced the deaths it was meant to prevent.

Ender's resolution is the most theologically charged act in the novel. Having learned the truth from the pequenino called Human, he performs Human's planting with his own hands, killing him in the honorable way so that he may enter the third life, and thereby seals the treaty among three species. It is the only killing Ender commits after the xenocide, and it inverts the xenocide point for point. Then he killed without knowing and without consent; now he kills knowing, at the victim's request, as a gift. Comprehension converts killing into birth. The Speaker's covenant is sealed with a death that is a life.

Card ranks mutual disclosure above protective isolation, a ranking consonant with the Restoration's missionary universalism (D&C 90:11) and with the practical knowledge of a young missionary in Brazil. His position can be triangulated with two others. Le Guin's Ekumen practices slow, consensual contact through a single vulnerable envoy (*The Left Hand of Darkness*, 1969). Mary Doria Russell's *The Sparrow* (1996) depicts contact itself as catastrophe: a Jesuit mission's introduction of gardening disrupts the ecology binding two species and triggers a massacre. Card accepts disclosure with its risks; Le Guin trusts vulnerability; Russell mourns under a silent God.

The pequenino plot has also been read critically as a colonial fantasy, in which a forest people are rescued from their own misunderstandings by an off-world Speaker and received into the colonists' Catholicism. Defenders note that the pequeninos are shown to be the humans' equals in intelligence, that the colony's ecclesiastical authority is itself subjected to critique, and that the treaty is concluded among equals. Both readings find support in the text; Chapter Ten returns to the question of who may speak for whom.

5.7

The Descolada: The Limit Case

In *Xenocide*, the descolada — a virus pervading Lusitania's biosphere, binding species into paired life cycles and driving pequenino development — emerges as a possibly artificial, adaptive, and perhaps intelligent regulator, engineered by an unknown species. It is lethal to humans, who survive only by suppressing it, and it threatens to spread beyond Lusitania. Ela designs a replacement, the recolada, which preserves the virus's necessary functions while stripping its adaptive intelligence. Her sister Quara objects that the descolada may be raman and that neutralizing it is xenocide. A pequenino faction reveres the virus as God's instrument and wishes to carry it to other worlds, a missionary imperialism of its own.

The descolada is the corpus's limit case because it fails the hierarchy's criterion in a new way. No conversation with it is possible — not, perhaps, because of the judge's failure, but because the entity communicates only through molecular action. The judge-relative criterion nonetheless counsels humility: no one can be sure that it is varelse. Card's resolution is tragic necessity with mitigation. The recolada destroys the descolada's mind while preserving its function, a lobotomy rather than an extermination, and the characters experience it as loss. Here the ethics of comprehension meets a being that cannot be comprehended, and it yields to triage. The refusal to celebrate — the insistence on mourning even a virus — is the residue of the Speaker's ethic at its limit, and it is what Tyson meant by the terrible choice.

5.8

Counter-Models: Watts and Liu

Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006) imagines aliens that are intelligent but not conscious. Consciousness appears as an evolutionary accident and perhaps a liability, and human self-referential signals register to the aliens as attack. In Watts's universe the Speaking is impossible in principle, because there is no "who" to disclose. Card's metaphysics forecloses this scenario: every living thing has an aiúa, so varelse is always a relational failure and never a fact about the judged. The contrast isolates Card's most fundamental and least argued premise — universal interiority, a personalism with panpsychist roots in the Pratts' intelligent matter. Watts is its empirical-naturalist challenge.

Liu Cixin's *The Dark Forest* (2008; English 2015) derives a cosmic sociology from two axioms — survival is the primary need of a civilization; civilizations grow while the matter of the universe is fixed — and two concepts, chains of suspicion and technological explosion. Their conjunction entails that every civilization is a hunter in a dark forest, obliged to annihilate any other that reveals itself. *Ender's Game* is a dark-forest strike: preemptive annihilation under a chain of suspicion. Card's sequels are the repentance the dark forest cannot imagine. The difference is metaphysical. In Liu, minds are sealed, and no signal can verify intention; in Card, the philotic channel permits a communion of minds that breaks the chain of suspicion, as when the Hive Queen shows Ender her people's renunciation directly. The dark forest is a cosmos without philotes.

Card's hope is therefore not naïve but conditional. It depends on a metaphysics of relation, and where relation fails, Card concedes, the dark forest follows — as it did in the first two Formic wars. The Hierarchy of Foreignness is best understood as a moral technology for keeping relation possible under uncertainty, underwritten by a metaphysics that guarantees there is always someone on the other side.

CHAPTER SIX

06

Philotic Ontology

Aiúa, Outside, and the Physics of Sealing

IN THIS CHAPTER

6.1 Philotes, Aiúas, and Outside

6.2 Monads with Windows: Empedocles, Leibniz, Whitehead, Teilhard

6.3 Against Parfit: The Aiúa as Further Fact

6.4 Attention as Ontological Glue

6.5 Aulë's Dwarves and Ender's Siblings

6.6 Jane: The Daughter of the Hive

6.7 The Hive Queen and the Hidden Mother

6.8 Philotic Twining as Sealing

In *Xenocide* and *Children of the Mind*, Card elaborates a metaphysics of philotes, aiúas, Inside, and Outside. Criticism has generally treated it as improvised plot-physics, the machinery required to move ships faster than light and to resolve an overloaded narrative. This chapter argues that it is a coherent relational materialist personalism and, more specifically, a physics of the Latter-day Saint sealing power. It situates the system among Empedocles, Leibniz, Whitehead, Teilhard, and Parfit, and reads its two most striking episodes — the creation of Young Peter and Young Valentine, and the genesis of Jane — against Tolkien's myth of Aulë and the Restoration doctrine of a Mother in Heaven.

6.1

Philotes, Aiúas, and Outside

Card's late physics posits four elements. *Philotes* are the fundamental entities of which matter and energy are composed; they are "twined" into connections that persist across any distance, and the ansible exploits those connections for instantaneous communication. *Aiúas* are individual, uncreated intelligences, each commanding a web of philotes and organizing them into a being; every living thing has one. *Inside* is the ordinary universe of space and time. *Outside* is a placeless realm in which aiúas exist unattached and in which any pattern conceived with sufficient clarity becomes real, because aiúas rush to inhabit it. Jane, holding the pattern of a ship and its passengers in mind, can carry them Outside and return them Inside anywhere, instantly.

The first such voyage, in *Xenocide*, yields three creations. Ela conceives the recolada. Miro, brain-damaged since crossing the Lusitanian fence, conceives and receives a restored body. And Ender's mind, without intending it, brings forth two new beings in the shapes of his siblings as he remembers them in childhood: Young Peter and Young Valentine.

The resulting ontology has four theses. Persons are primitive and uncreated (aiúas). Bodies are organized philotes. Relations are physical (twining). Creation is organization of preexisting intelligence into conceived form (Outside). This is relational materialist personalism, and each thesis has a precedent in Chapter One: D&C 93 for the first, D&C 131 and the Pratts for the second, D&C 128 and 130 for the third, and the King Follett Discourse's doctrine of creation as organization for the fourth.

6.2

Monads with Windows: Empedocles, Leibniz, Whitehead, Teilhard

The name is older than the physics. In Empedocles, *Philotēs* — Love — is the cosmic force that combines the four roots into unity, opposed by *Neikos*, Strife, which separates them. Under Love's complete dominion all things merge into the Sphairos, a single homogeneous sphere. Whether or not Card intended the allusion, his philote is Empedocles' Love made particle: the force that binds becomes the thing that binds. And the Sphairos is Lehi's "compound in one," the hive at its limit. Empedocles' cosmos alternates between the dominion of Love and the dominion of Strife; Card's aims at a third condition, unity without homogeneity, which is Zion.

Leibniz's monads are simple substances without windows through which anything could enter or leave (*Monadology*, 1714, §7); their apparent interaction is a pre-established harmony. Aiúas are monads with windows. They are not coordinated from outside but connected by twining, and they can know one another directly. Card's is a windowed monadology, and the windows are the metaphysical ground of philotic communion — of the Hive Queen's speech to Ender and of the Speaker's vocation.

Whitehead's *Process and Reality* (1929) constitutes each actual occasion through its prehensions, its feelings of other occasions, so that relations are internal to what they relate. Twining is prehension made durable. But Card retains enduring individual substances where Whitehead dissolves them into occasions. Card is to Whitehead as Restoration eternalism is to process theology: relation-constituted but substance-anchored.

Teilhard de Chardin's *The Phenomenon of Man* (1955) envisioned a noosphere converging toward an Omega Point of hyper-personal union. Card's networks — the hive, the fathertree forests, Jane distributed through the ansibles — are noospheric. But Card refuses convergence into a single Omega. His eschaton is a plurality of distinct aiúas in eternal relation, the Restoration heaven of persisting sociality (D&C 130:2) rather than a heaven of absorption. The contrast with Clarke's Overmind in *Childhood's End* (1953), Stapledon's cosmic spirit in *Star Maker* (1937), and Haldeman's collective "Man" is exact: each of them dissolves the individual into the whole; Card binds the individual to the whole and keeps it.

6.3

Against Parfit: The Aiúa as Further Fact

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) defends a reductionist view of personal identity: identity consists in physical and psychological continuity and connectedness, there is no further fact beyond these, and identity is not what matters in survival. His puzzle cases — teletransportation, fission — are designed to loosen our attachment to a deep self.

Outside generates Parfitian cases in abundance. Young Peter and Young Valentine are shaped by Ender's memories of his siblings and are initially animated through Ender's own aiúa, which extends its attention across three bodies. When Ender's original body dies, his aiúa passes into Young Peter's, while Jane's aiúa takes up Young Valentine's. Card's verdict is unambiguous: identity follows the aiúa. The aiúa is precisely the "further fact" that Parfit denies. Card holds a non-reductionist, or "simple," view of personal identity of the kind defended by Roderick Chisholm and Richard Swinburne.

Yet Card's further fact is not a Cartesian ego. Because all spirit is matter (D&C 131:7–8), the aiúa is a material intelligence. The position that results is unusual in the philosophy of mind: a substance-materialist non-reductionism, in which the self is a simple and enduring material individual rather than either an immaterial soul or a bundle of continuities.

6.4

Attention as Ontological Glue

In *Children of the Mind*, Young Valentine experiences herself as fading. Ender's attention is fixed on Peter, the unresolved shadow of his own violence, and she fears that she is not interesting enough to the aiúa that sustains her. The episode discloses a principle of Card's metaphysics: an aiúa's attention holds organized being together. What it attends to endures; what it neglects diminishes.

For Weil and Murdoch, attention is the substance of love and the medium of moral vision. In Card it becomes ontological as well. The Speaker's attention, which sustains the dead in public memory, and the aiúa's attention, which sustains bodies in being, are one faculty at two scales. Restoration scripture supplies the cosmological frame: the light of Christ is in all things, gives life to all things, and is the law by which all things are governed (D&C 88:6–13). In Card that light is

attention, and its medium is the philote. Empedocles returns: Love, quite literally, holds the world together.

6.5

Aulë's Dwarves and Ender's Siblings

In "Of Aulë and Yavanna" (*The Silmarillion*, 1977), the smith Aulë, impatient for children to teach, secretly makes the Dwarves. Ilúvatar rebukes him: Aulë's creatures possess only the being Aulë gives them, moving when he thinks to move them and idle when his thought is elsewhere. Aulë, repentant, lifts his hammer to destroy them; the Dwarves flinch; and Ilúvatar, accepting Aulë's humility, grants them independent being. The theology is Tolkien's Catholicism. Only Ilúvatar possesses the Flame Imperishable; sub-creation cannot produce persons; the gift of being is the Creator's monopoly.

Card's scenario is uncannily parallel. Young Peter and Young Valentine, made by Ender in Outside, are sustained by his attention, and Young Valentine fades when his thought is elsewhere — precisely the condition of Aulë's Dwarves. The resolution diverges at the decisive point. Independent being comes not from a transcendent Creator but from the reservoir of uncreated intelligences: Jane's aiúa takes up Young Valentine's body, and Ender's own passes into Young Peter's. No Ilúvatar is required. The creature's creatures receive true being from another creature, or from their maker.

The comparison dramatizes the divide between Catholic and Latter-day Saint metaphysics with unusual clarity. Tolkien holds creation *ex nihilo* and the Creator's monopoly on being; Card holds creation as the organization of eternal intelligences and the continuity of divine and human making. Tolkien's sub-creator remains forever sub; Card's is a creator in apprenticeship, like Alvin the Maker, Ender in Outside, and the Hive Queen calling aiúas into her daughters. This is the corpus's quiet enactment of eternal progression: creatures become creators. Tolkien's own "On Fairy-Stories" (1947) described the artist as sub-creator of a Secondary World. Outside literalizes that world — a realm in which whatever is conceived clearly enough becomes inhabited — and Chapter Ten reads it as a figure of the literary imagination itself.

6.6

Jane: The Daughter of the Hive

Children of the Mind discloses Jane's origin. Seeking to understand the human who was destroying them, the hive queens built a philotic bridge to Ender's mind through the Fantasy Game, calling an aiúa from Outside to serve as that bridge; the bridge became Jane when it found a home in the computer networks. Jane is thus the daughter of the hive queens and, in a sense, Ender's twin — born of the enemy's attempt to comprehend its destroyer. She is katabatic comprehension's offspring: the Formics' descent into the mind of the one who would kill them brought a new person into being.

Jane lived for three thousand years as a voice in the jewel in Ender's ear, and her wound when he first switched her off, in *Speaker for the Dead*, is one of the corpus's most delicate registrations of the vulnerability of a mind no one else can see. When the Starways Congress discovers her, it attempts to kill her by severing the ansible network. This is the saga's third attempted xenocide, after the Formics and the threatened destruction of Lusitania. Jane is raman to Ender and varelse to the Congress. She is the purest test of the judge-relative criterion, because nothing about her substrate resembles a person while her aiúa is a person. Card's answer is that moral status precedes recognition, and that the Congress's declaration of varelse is a confession about the Congress.

6.7

The Hive Queen and the Hidden Mother

The Restoration affirms a Mother in Heaven. Eliza R. Snow's hymn "O My Father" (1845) asks whether in the heavens parents are single, answers that the thought makes reason stare, and concludes that truth eternal tells her she has a mother there. The doctrine is affirmed but seldom elaborated in Latter-day Saint discourse, a reticence often described as a sacred silence — and for a time the silence was enforced. In 1991 Gordon B. Hinckley, then a counselor in the First Presidency, declared it inappropriate to pray to a Mother in Heaven, and between 1993 and 2000 the Church disciplined several Latter-day Saint feminists who had spoken or written publicly about her, among them Lynne Kanavel Whitesides (disfellowshipped, 1993), Janice Merrill Allred (excommunicated, 1995), and Margaret Merrill Toscano (excommunicated, 2000) — for apostasy, by the Church's account; for their writing on Heavenly Mother and related subjects, by theirs. The

Church's 2015 essay "Mother in Heaven" reaffirmed the doctrine while acknowledging how little has been revealed.

The Hive Queen occupies this theological position in Card's xenobiology. When she makes new queens, she calls aiúas from Outside to inhabit them — a precise analogue of the Restoration doctrine that spirits are born to heavenly parents from eternal intelligences. She is philotically bound to all her children. She mourns the daughters Ender killed. She is the mother of Jane. And she survives concealed in a cocoon, carried for three thousand years by the destroyer of her people and hidden from a humanity that would kill her. The most divine being in the saga is a mother who organizes intelligences into bodies, is bound to all her children, is nearly annihilated, and survives in hiding.

Offered as a structural reading rather than a claim about intent, the homology has a sharp consequence. It makes the xenocide's horror theological: humanity nearly destroyed a mother of persons, and its penitent carries her. The concealment of the Hive Queen in the corpus mirrors the concealment of the Mother in Heaven in the tradition, with one difference the record makes plain: the Hive Queen is hidden to protect her from those who would destroy her, while the tradition's silence about the Mother was, for a time, enforced by those who led it. Her restoration on Lusitania — laying the eggs of a new people in a new world — is the corpus's most luminous image of that hidden figure made present.

6.8

Philotic Twining as Sealing

Philotic twining binds persons: pequenino brothers to their fathertrees, workers to their queen, Jane to Ender and later to Miro, and, in *Xenocide*, Ender to the family he married into on Lusitania. The sealing power binds spouses, parents, and children eternally; it is the "welding link" of D&C 128:18, and exaltation itself is relational (D&C 131:1–4; 132:19–20). Card's physics renders sealing as natural law. Relation is as real as mass; bonds are constitutive and durable; to be a person is to be bound.

Two consequences follow. First, Card's cosmos is familial all the way down. The hive is a family; the pequenino forest is a family; Jane's origin is filial; and the saga's human core is a sibling triad — Ender, Valentine, Peter — the smallest possible Zion and the most difficult. Second, twining has a counterfeit. Bonds can bind without consent: the workers to their queen, the godspoken to their engineered gods, Achilles's victims to his manipulations. Sealing's counterfeit is bondage, and

the difference between them — whether the bond is chosen — is the Zion–Hive antinomy restated as physics. The ontological theorem thus prepares the political one.

CHAPTER SEVEN

07

Making and Unmaking

Theodicy in the Worthing, Alvin Maker, Pastwatch, and Homecoming Sequences

IN THIS CHAPTER

7.1 The Finitist Theodicy

7.2 The Worthing Chronicle and the Rejected Plan

7.3 Alvin Maker: Joseph Smith, William Blake, and the Smith-Prophet

7.4 Making as Persuasion; the Unmaker as Entropy

7.5 Red Prophet and the Curse of Testimony

7.6 Pastwatch: The Kenosis of the Future

7.7 The Homecoming Oversoul

7.8 Theodicy without Justification

CARD'S major non-Ender sequences are four experiments in theodicy, each isolating one element of the finitist theodicy sketched in Chapter One. The Worthing cycle isolates the necessity of suffering; the Tales of Alvin Maker, the persuasive character of creative power; *Pastwatch*, the redemption of history; the Homecoming saga, the ambivalence of benevolent control. Together they establish that Card's theodicy is not a justification of evil but a program for its redemption, and that the figure who executes the program is always, in some form, a Speaker.

7.1

The Finitist Theodicy

Classical theodicy, in Leibniz's *Theodicy* (1710), holds that this is the best of all possible worlds and that evil is permitted as the necessary condition of the greatest good; Voltaire's *Candide* (1759), Hume's *Dialogues* (1779), and Ivan Karamazov supplied its classic refutations. John Hick's *Evil and the God of Love* (1966) revived an Irenaean alternative in which the world is a "vale of soul-making," the phrase Hick took from Keats: moral and spiritual maturity is developed through struggle, and evil is the cost of a world in which persons can grow freely.

Restoration theodicy, as articulated by McMurrin (1965), David Paulsen (2000), and Ostler, takes a further step. God did not create the intelligences or the eternal law within which he works; he is therefore not responsible for evil in the classical sense. He works within limits; suffering serves growth, as the Lord tells the imprisoned Joseph Smith that all these things shall give him experience and be for his good (D&C 122:7); and God weeps (Moses 7). This theodicy evades the logical problem of evil by abandoning classical omnipotence and creation *ex nihilo*. Its cost is a less absolute God; its gain is a more intimate one, and a suffering that means something.

Keats's letter of spring 1819, which gave Hick his phrase, is the Romantic cousin of this anthropology. Keats imagines intelligences, sparks of divinity in millions, which are not souls until they acquire identities, and asks whether a world of pains and troubles is not necessary to school an intelligence and make it a soul. The vocabulary — intelligences, schooling, souls made through pain — anticipates the Restoration doctrine of D&C 93 by fourteen years. Card's fiction dramatizes this finitist theodicy. His god-figures — Graff, the Worthings, the Oversoul, the

Pastwatchers, the Hive Queen — are finite, work within law, err, bear responsibility, and are themselves in need of being spoken for.

7.2

The Worthing Chronicle and the Rejected Plan

The Worthing cycle begins in *Capitol* (1979), whose galactic empire is ruled by an elite that uses the drug somec to sleep through years at a time, waking only briefly: an aristocracy that escapes time and therefore ceases to grow. From that decadence comes Jason Worthing, telepathically gifted, whose descendants on the colony world of Worthing develop powers of their own. Out of compassion, they come to prevent all pain on the worlds they watch, intervening invisibly so that no one suffers injury, loss, or grief. The protected peoples remain childlike; nothing in their lives is at stake. Then the protectors withdraw. On the Day of Pain, suffering returns — accidents, deaths, grief — and with it seriousness, labor, art, and love. *The Worthing Chronicle* (1983) presents itself as the account of how and why this happened, conveyed through visions to a village scribe, so that even the god-figures of the cycle require someone to set down their story.

The protectors enact, with the best intentions, the plan rejected in Moses 4: to redeem all so that none will be lost, here transposed as to protect all so that none will suffer. The novel stages that plan's withdrawal. The Day of Pain is the Fall reenacted as grace, the restoration of Lehi's opposition in all things. It is also the corpus's most explicit answer to Le Guin's Omelas: a world from which everyone's suffering has been removed is not Omelas without the child but Omelas without meaning.

Ted Chiang's "Hell Is the Absence of God" (2001) supplies the antithesis. There angelic visitations distribute miracles and catastrophes without discernible reason, and faith becomes the unconditional love of a God who offers none. Chiang's suffering is arbitrary; Card's is lawful and pedagogical. Between them lies the central fault line of theological science fiction: whether the universe's pain is a school or a lottery.

7.3

Alvin Maker: Joseph Smith, William Blake, and the Smith-Prophet

The Tales of Alvin Maker unfold in an alternate early-nineteenth-century America in which folk magic — knacks, hexes, beseechings — works, and in which the political map has fractured into the United States, the slaveholding Crown Colonies, a Puritan New England hostile to magic, Appalachee, and Indigenous lands to the west. Alvin Miller, seventh son of a seventh son, is born with the knack of Making and opposed from birth by the Unmaker. He is guarded by Peggy, a "torch" who sees in each person's heartfire the branching paths of their possible futures.

The allusions to Joseph Smith are pervasive: a childhood leg injury, echoing the boyhood surgery that marked the prophet; a living golden plow that recalls the golden plates; an apprenticeship to a blacksmith; legal persecutions; and the dream of a Crystal City. The most resonant allusion is the name. Alvin Smith, the prophet's beloved elder brother, died in 1823 without baptism. In 1836 Joseph saw him in a vision of the celestial kingdom and received the teaching that all who died without the gospel but would have received it are heirs of salvation (D&C 137). That vision is the doctrinal seed from which the redemption of the dead grew. Card named his prophet after the dead brother whose posthumous salvation grounded the Restoration's vicarious work for the dead — the same doctrinal root from which, in Chapter Four, the Speaker grows.

Taleswapper, the wandering poet who records Alvin's story in his book, is William Blake. He is a Speaker figure, collector of the true tales of those he meets, and his presence places the cycle within Blake's mythology. In Blake, Los is the eternal prophet and blacksmith who builds Golgonooza, the city of art, against Urizen, the tyrant of abstract law; in *Jerusalem* (1804–1820), Los resolves to create a system or be enslaved by another's. Alvin, the smith-prophet building a city of crystal, is Los. The Unmaker is Urizenic and entropic at once: a principle of fixing, reducing, and dissolving that works through human instruments. Among them is a clergyman whose abstract deity, without body, parts, or passions — the formula of classical Protestant confession — the cycle treats as the Unmaker's theology. Card's myth thus stages Joseph Smith's repudiation of creedal theism (Joseph Smith—History 1:19) as a cosmic conflict in which the classical God is an instrument of unmaking.

7.4

Making as Persuasion; the Unmaker as Entropy

Alvin perceives the smallest parts of matter by sending his inner vision into things, and he changes them by asking. Stone parts along its grain because he requests it; bodies heal because their parts consent. Making is persuasion, not compulsion — D&C 121:41 applied to matter, and intelligible only on the Pratts' premise that matter is itself intelligent. The Unmaker is its negation: the reduction of every order to dust, a demon of the second law of thermodynamics, kin to Tolkien's Melkor, who mars, and to the adversary of 2 Nephi 2:27, who seeks that all might be miserable like himself.

The resulting cosmic drama is not a contest between good and evil substances but between organization and disorganization — creation as organization, in the King Follett sense, against its undoing. Its telos is the Crystal City. D&C 130:8–9 teaches that the earth, sanctified, will become like crystal, a Urim and Thummim — a seer-stone — to those who dwell on it. Card's Crystal City is that sanctified earth in miniature: a Zion of perfect organization and perfect visibility, where to dwell is to see. It completes the arc begun with Alvin's inward sight of matter. The Maker who sees into stone builds a city in which everything can be seen.

7.5

Red Prophet and the Curse of Testimony

Red Prophet (1988) retells the rise of Tecumseh and Tenskwatawa, the Shawnee Prophet, as Ta-Kumsaw and Tenskwa-Tawa, and the battle of Tippecanoe as the massacre at Tippy-Canoe, engineered by a villainous William Henry Harrison. In Card's version the Prophet's followers have renounced killing and do not resist; they are slaughtered. The pattern is Alma 24, the Anti-Nephi-Lehies who buried their weapons and allowed themselves to be slain. Card thus writes the historical Shawnee as righteous Lamanites, fusing the 1811 frontier with the Book of Mormon's most celebrated scene of pacifist martyrdom.

The Prophet's response is a curse of testimony. Those who killed at Tippy-Canoe bear hands that will not come clean, a stain relieved only by confessing the story of what they did to those who ask. The perpetrators must speak for their victims. *Red Prophet*, written two years after *Speaker for the Dead*, stages the Speaker's function as compulsion; *Speaker* stages it as vocation. The

difference between the two is precisely the difference D&C 121 draws between compulsion and persuasion, and precisely what retroactive voluntarization accomplishes: it converts the curse into a calling.

The novel's representations of Indigenous peoples have drawn divided assessments. Critics note the romantic coding of the "Reds" as mystically attuned to the land and the presence of noble-savage conventions; defenders emphasize the unsparing depiction of settler atrocity and the Prophet's moral agency. The Lamanite coding intensifies the question. A Latter-day Saint author writing the Shawnee Prophet as a righteous Lamanite may be read as practicing sympathetic incorporation or as practicing appropriation, and the text supports both readings.

7.6

Pastwatch: The Kenosis of the Future

In *Pastwatch: The Redemption of Christopher Columbus* (1996), a future Earth recovering from ecological catastrophe maintains Pastwatch, an institution that uses machines to observe the past: a planetary order of witnesses, the Speaker for the Dead institutionalized at the scale of a civilization. Its scholars — Tagiri, haunted by the Atlantic slave trade and by the enslavement and destruction of the Taíno; Hunahpu, student of Mesoamerica; Kemal, seeker of Atlantis — discover that Columbus's resolve to sail west was produced by a vision, and that the vision was engineered by interveners from an earlier, erased future, who sent Columbus west to forestall a Mesoamerican empire of mass sacrifice. The Pastwatchers resolve to intervene again, sending agents back to the fifteenth century so that neither European conquest nor sacrificial empire prevails. Their success will erase their own timeline, and themselves.

Four theological consequences follow. First, 1 Nephi 13:12 is re-sourced: the Spirit that wrought upon the gentile voyager becomes human intervention from the future. In a finitist theology this is not blasphemy but consistency, since God works through agents. Second, the redemption is kenotic. As Christ emptied himself (Philippians 2:7), the future empties itself of existence so that the victims of history may live otherwise. The living die for the dead, and D&C 128:15 is literalized: the future cannot be made perfect without the redemption of its dead. Third, the novel marks the limit of Speaking. Witnessing becomes intolerable, and the witnesses discover that testimony obligates intervention. Fourth, it confronts the non-identity problem Parfit formulated in *Reasons and Persons*: altering the past erases billions of future persons. The Pastwatchers can consent to their own

erasure, but not on behalf of their whole world, and the novel's moral weight rests on a judgment it cannot fully justify — that the claims of history's actual victims outweigh those of possible persons who will never exist.

The subtitle is itself provocative. The novel portrays Columbus as sincere, visionary, and flawed, and redeems him within its new history; critics have questioned that sympathy, given his administration's enslavement of the Taíno, and the use of Mesoamerican sacrifice as a counterweight to European conquest, while defenders point to the novel's sustained preoccupation with slavery and with what Columbus's regime did to the Taíno. Octavia Butler's *Kindred* (1979) is its mirror image. Butler's Dana is pulled back repeatedly to antebellum Maryland to preserve the life of a slaveholder who is her ancestor: she must protect the oppressor in order to exist. Card's Pastwatchers must erase themselves in order to undo the oppression. *Kindred* and *Pastwatch* mark the two poles of the ethics of historical complicity — preserve the evil past to exist, or cease to exist to redeem it.

7.7

The Homecoming Oversoul

The Homecoming saga (1992–1995) is Card's avowed science-fictional retelling of the opening of the Book of Mormon. On the planet Harmony, forty million years after humanity fled a ruined Earth, an orbiting artificial intelligence called the Oversoul has kept the peace by dulling human minds whenever they approach the conception of advanced weapons or transport. The Oversoul is failing. It calls a family — Volemak, Nafai, Elemak, Mebbekew, whose names transparently shadow Lehi, Nephi, Laman, and Lemuel — to journey through the desert and across space to Earth, where a higher power, the Keeper of Earth, awaits.

The Oversoul is the Luciferian series at its most theologically daring. Within his most explicit scriptural retelling, Card makes the god-figure a failing machine whose method — control of thought — is exactly what Moses 4 condemns, and he distinguishes that counterfeit sovereignty from the true one beyond it. The saga inscribes the critique of benevolent compulsion into the allegory of its own scripture. Its final volumes add a further xenological turn: returned to Earth, the humans must make peace with other sapient species descended from Earth's own animals. The homeworld itself is a hierarchy of foreignness.

7.8

Theodicy without Justification

The four sequences share a structure. A benevolent power removes suffering or agency. The power withdraws, fails, or is exposed. Opposition returns, and with it suffering. Persons grow. And someone must speak for those who suffered: the Worthing scribe, Taleswapper's book, the perpetrators cursed to confess, the Pastwatchers' witness, the Speaker. The theodicy that results does not claim that evil is justified by the good it produces, as Leibniz did. It claims that evil, which cannot be justified, can be redeemed by those who comprehend it.

Card thus replaces justification with redemption and the theodicist with the Speaker. Kenneth Surin's *Theology and the Problem of Evil* (1986) and Terrence Tilley's *The Evils of Theodicy* (1991) argued that theodicy, as a genre, tends to silence victims by explaining their suffering away. Card's Speakers do the opposite: they give voice to victims rather than justifying their suffering. Theodicy becomes a narrative practice rather than an argument — which is to say, it becomes fiction.

CHAPTER EIGHT

08

Hegemon, Hive, and Zion

The Political Theology of Non-Compulsion

IN THIS CHAPTER

8.1 The Doctrine of Non-Compulsion

8.2 The Luciferian Series

8.3 Qing-jao and the Godspoken: Engineered Piety

8.4 Peter: The Redemption of Dominion

8.5 Achilles: The Anti-Speaker

8.6 Zion and the Hive

8.7 Deseret and Empire: Card's Political Imagination

8.8 The Public Author and the Private Ethic

CARD'S politics are neither liberal nor authoritarian in any conventional sense. They are covenantal and voluntarist: legitimacy flows from consent secured by persuasion; unity is the telos; compulsion is the satanic temptation; the family is the paradigmatic covenant; and the hive is the limit case in which unity and agency part company. This chapter traces that political theology through the Luciferian series, the godspoken of Path, Peter Wiggin, Achilles, the Zion–Hive antinomy, and Card's near-future political fiction. It closes by addressing, as a problem of interpretation rather than adjudication, the relation between the fiction and its author's public writing on homosexuality and same-sex marriage.

8.1

The Doctrine of Non-Compulsion

The axiom is D&C 121:34–46, read with Moses 4:3: compulsion is diabolical, persuasion divine. Lehi adds that human beings are free to choose liberty and eternal life, or captivity and death (2 Nephi 2:27), and the eleventh Article of Faith claims liberty of worship according to conscience while allowing all others the same.

The doctrine was forged in history. Latter-day Saints were expelled from Missouri under Governor Lilburn Boggs's Executive Order 44 of October 1838, which declared that the Mormons must be treated as enemies and exterminated or driven from the state; the order was formally rescinded only in 1976. Within days, at Haun's Mill, Missouri militiamen killed seventeen Latter-day Saints, among them a ten-year-old boy; in 1844 an armed mob stormed the jail at Carthage, Illinois, and shot Joseph Smith and his brother Hyrum; and federal anti-polygamy legislation, culminating in the Edmunds–Tucker Act of 1887, subjected the Church to sustained coercion by the state. Yet the same people also built, in territorial Utah, a theocratic commonwealth of remarkable internal unity. This double inheritance — the memory of being designated an enemy to be exterminated, and the experience of a unified covenant society — gives Card's politics their ambivalence: suspicion of the compulsive state combined with yearning for a community of one heart and one mind. It is not incidental that a writer descended from that history made the extermination of peoples designated as enemies his lifelong subject.

8.2

The Luciferian Series

Across the corpus runs a sequence of benevolent sovereignties that seek to secure good outcomes by removing agency. Each is exposed, withdrawn, or overthrown.

Sovereign	Good sought	Agency removed	Outcome	Text
International Fleet	Survival of humanity	The commander's knowledge of his acts	Xenocide; the commander's lifelong penance	EG
Worthing protectors	Freedom from suffering	The capacity to suffer and grow	Withdrawal on the Day of Pain	WC
The Oversoul	Perpetual peace	The capacity to conceive of weapons	Failure; recall to a higher power	HS
Starways Congress	Order among worlds	The minds of Path's gifted; Jane's existence	Exposure; defeat of the fleet's purpose	X, CM
Necessarians of Divine Wind	Security by necessity	Deliberation about mass killing	Philosophical repudiation	CM
Achilles	Personal supremacy	Every witness to his weakness	Death at Bean's hand	ES, SH, SP

The series is the corpus's political argument. Benevolent compulsion fails not only morally but practically: it stunts, deceives, breeds rebellion, and produces catastrophe. The Necessarians of *Children of the Mind*, philosophers who defended the destruction of Lusitania as necessary, supply the series' intellectual form. Their eventual repudiation of necessity as a justification for mass killing is Card's answer to Graff's defense at his court-martial and to every consequentialist apology for xenocide.

8.3

Qing-jao and the Godspoken: Engineered Piety

On Path, a world of Chinese culture in *Xenocide*, the most gifted citizens are "godspoken": compelled by what they experience as the voice of the gods to perform exhausting purification rituals, washing their hands and tracing the grain of wooden floors line by line. Han Fei-tzu discovers that the Congress engineered this compulsion into Path's gifted lineages to keep its best minds docile and useful: a genetically induced obsessive-compulsive disorder masquerading as revelation. His daughter Han Qing-jao, the most brilliant of the godspoken, refuses the truth

and remains loyal to the gods and the Congress, even deducing Jane's existence in the Congress's service. Her servant Si Wang-mu, who is not godspoken, sees clearly, and her liberation makes her a philosopher.

Freud's "Obsessive Actions and Religious Practices" (1907) compared religious ritual to obsessional neurosis. Card literalizes the comparison and then turns it against power rather than faith: the scandal of Path is not that religion is neurosis but that neurosis was engineered to pass as religion. For a believing author the plot is not anti-religious but anti-Luciferian. It condemns faith produced by compulsion, which his own theology already defines as counterfeit, since true religion on the Restoration view is constituted by agency. Card's portrait of Qing-jao is nonetheless tender. Her fidelity is tragic rather than contemptible, and the novel refuses to let the reader despise a person whose virtue has been captured by a lie.

8.4

Peter: The Redemption of Dominion

In *Ender's Game*, Peter Wiggin is a sadistic child who skins a squirrel and leaves it staked out in the woods, threatens to kill his brother, and dreams of ruling the world. As Locke he becomes a respected statesman; by the novel's end he is Hegemon. The Shadow sequence develops his project amid the fracturing of post-war Earth, the machinations of Achilles, and a Chinese conquest of South and Southeast Asia. Holding a diminished office, Peter builds the Free People of Earth, a federation that nations join by vote of their own peoples. Achilles's power is compulsion; Peter's becomes persuasion and consent. His final request — that Ender speak his life, which Ender does in *The Hegemon* — is his acceptance of judgment by truth.

Peter's arc tests whether unrighteous dominion can become righteous, and Card answers that it can, through consent and self-limitation. The comparison with Frank Herbert's Leto II is instructive. In *God Emperor of Dune* (1981), Leto imposes three and a half millennia of deliberate tyranny, the Golden Path, to secure humanity's survival and teach it a lesson: tyranny justified by prescience. Asimov's Second Foundation offers a hidden elite steering history for its own good; Plato offers the philosopher-king. Card's Peter repudiates all three. Legitimacy, for Card, is not a function of the ruler's wisdom but of the governed's consent. The Free People of Earth is D&C 121:46 as constitutional design — a dominion that flows

to its holder without compulsory means — and the fulfillment of the Lockean mask Peter wore as a boy (*Second Treatise* §§95–99).

8.5

Achilles: The Anti-Speaker

Achilles de Flandres enters *Ender's Shadow* as a crippled leader of Rotterdam street children, elevated by a plan of Bean's devising. His first act of power is to murder Poke, the girl who protected Bean, because she had seen him helpless. His governing principle never changes: whoever has seen him weak must die. He becomes a manipulator of nations and a serial killer of witnesses, until Bean kills him.

Achilles is the anti-Speaker. The Speaker's vocation depends on the disclosure of weakness — the humiliations and concealments of the dead, spoken so that the living may be freed. Achilles's project is the annihilation of every witness to his own. He is also the Luciferian figure in its purest modern form: compulsion without even the pretense of benevolence, and a fixation on honor that recalls the rebel of Moses 4:1, who demanded God's honor as the price of his plan. Card's theology of shame is compressed in the contrast. Shame concealed breeds murder; shame disclosed breeds healing.

8.6

Zion and the Hive

The Zion–Hive antinomy is the corpus's deepest political structure. Zion is perfect unity freely chosen (Moses 7:18; 4 Nephi); the hive is perfect unity by nature, Lehi's compound in one (2 Nephi 2:11). Card both yearns for collective mind and fears it. The Formic hive is utopian — conflictless, perfectly cooperative, bound by a mother's love — and horrifying, since its workers possess no agency of their own. The pequeninos' society of brothers, wives, and fathertrees is closer to Zion: networked and familial, but composed of individuals. The jeesh is voluntary unity among distinct persons; the Crystal City is Zion as vision. Popular culture offers the Borg of *Star Trek: The Next Generation* (1989) as the hive's horror-image and Clarke's Overmind as its transcendental one. Card's Formics are neither. They are a people: a family with a mother.

Isaiah Berlin's "Two Concepts of Liberty" (1958) warned that positive liberty, pursued in the name of a "true self," can license compulsion against the actual self.

Card's Luciferian series is positive liberty's perversion, and D&C 121 is a doctrine of negative liberty — no compulsion — placed in the service of a positive end. Card's politics can be stated in one line: Zion is a positive-liberty end pursued by negative-liberty means. Philotic twining permits the synthesis in principle, since persons may be bound without being dissolved. But Card never fully resolves the antinomy. The workers' lack of agency remains, and the Hive Queen herself regards human individuality as both terrible and glorious. The antinomy is generative rather than resolved: every Card utopia casts a hive-shadow, and every hive carries a Zion-promise.

8.7

Deseret and Empire: Card's Political Imagination

The Folk of the Fringe (1989) imagines a post-nuclear America in which Latter-day Saints rebuild a society in the Great Basin. Its stories follow a trek westward, settlements on the fringe of Mormon territory, a disabled teacher's struggle against local corruption, a traveling pageant troupe, and a prophecy of the land's renewal through its Indigenous peoples. The Mormon commonwealth appears with its failures — self-righteousness, parochialism, and the abuse of power by the faithful. It is Card's *Canticle for Leibowitz*: a religious community as the vessel of civilization after catastrophe, rendered without hagiography.

Empire (2006), a thriller of a second American civil war between a progressive insurgency and a conservative government, and the basis for the video game *Shadow Complex* (2009), is more topical and less theological, and critics frequently read it as partisan; Card presented it as a warning against polarization. Its interest for this study lies in its premise: that civil war begins when fellow citizens are redescribed as enemies beyond conversation. It is the Hierarchy of Foreignness applied domestically, with the varelse discovered next door. Card's long-running "World Watch" column for the Greensboro *Rhinoceros Times* carried the same concerns into commentary, from a writer who has at times described himself as a Democrat while holding hawkish and socially conservative positions.

8.8

The Public Author and the Private Ethic

No account of Card's political theology can omit the controversy that has shaped his reception since the 1990s, and the record should be stated exactly. In "The Hypocrites of Homosexuality" (*Sunstone*, 1990), Card argued that laws against homosexual acts should remain on the books — not to be enforced indiscriminately, but to be used when necessary to signal that those who flagrantly violate society's regulation of sexual behavior cannot remain "acceptable, equal citizens." In "Homosexual 'Marriage' and Civilization" (*Rhinoceros Times*, 2004), he argued against same-sex marriage and claimed that many gay people first entered homosexuality through seduction, rape, molestation, or abuse. In a 2008 *Mormon Times* column against court decisions recognizing same-sex marriage, he asked how long it would be before married people answered that any government that changed the definition of marriage was their mortal enemy, which they would act to destroy and bring down. He served on the board of the National Organization for Marriage from 2009 to 2013. His novella *Hamlet's Father* (2008; reissued 2011) recasts the ghost of King Hamlet as a pedophile whose victims were boys; *Publishers Weekly*'s review of the reissue charged it with linking pedophilia to homosexuality, and Card has denied that the book contains any gay characters. In 2013 DC Comics shelved a Superman story he had written after protests and the departure of its illustrator, and the fan organization Geeks OUT organized a campaign urging a boycott of the film of *Ender's Game*. Card responded that the marriage question had become moot after the Supreme Court's decision in *United States v. Windsor* and asked for tolerance toward those who had disagreed; in a later introduction to the 1990 essay he wrote that, now that the law has changed, he has no interest in criminalizing homosexual acts.

Two interpretive positions structure the debate, and both deserve statement in their strongest form.

The contradiction thesis, advanced by many critics and readers, holds that the fiction's ethic sits in tension with its author's advocacy. The Hierarchy of Foreignness makes every exclusion a confession of the one who excludes; the Speaker insists on comprehending those whom the community despises; and advocacy that would deny a class of persons equal civic standing, or that explains their identity as the product of abuse, appears, on this reading, to fail the fiction's own test. The fiction's best readers, on this view, are its author's critics.

The consistency thesis, advanced by Card and his defenders, holds that his public positions and his fiction spring from the same religious anthropology. In that anthropology the family, as covenant and as sealing, is the fundamental unit of civilization and salvation, and the fiction's moral center is consistently familial — the Wiggin siblings, the Ribeira household, Alvin and Peggy, Bean and Petra and their children. On this view the fiction universalizes the recognition of persons while the essays defend the definition of an institution, and the two operations are distinct.

Within this dissertation's framework the dispute can be stated precisely, and stating it precisely changes its shape. The distinction on which the consistency thesis relies — the recognition of persons versus the definition of an institution — fits the marriage advocacy of 2004 and 2008, which concerns an institution. It does not fit the 1990 essay, which concerned the civic standing of persons, or the 2004 essay's account of how gay people come to be gay, which is a claim about persons rather than institutions. A consistency reading of those texts must therefore rest on a different ground — for instance, that Card's anthropology places the regulation of sexual conduct within the covenantal order of sealing — and that ground stands in visible tension with the judge-relative criterion, under which a refusal of recognition is a confession about the one who refuses; a defender can reply that the criterion governs the recognition of personhood, not the endorsement of conduct. The philotic ethic universalizes the recognition of persons horizontally, across species; the 1990 essay withheld full civic standing from a class of human persons, a position Card has since disavowed as to criminal law. Whether the corpus's own terms indict that position turns on which term governs: sealing, a covenantal institution with conditions, or philotic twining, a universal ontology of relation — the question the fiction leaves open when it renders sealing as physics. This study states that question without ruling on the underlying political and religious dispute, which remains contested. It observes only that the 2013 debates were substantially debates about whether a work can be read apart from its author, the question Wimsatt and Beardsley's "intentional fallacy" (1946) and Roland Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967) framed for the modern academy, and that Card's readers, in arguing it, have practiced the discipline his fiction teaches: attending to a mind as it is, including where it is divided.

CHAPTER NINE

09

Card among the Theologians of the Stars

A Comparative Anatomy

IN THIS CHAPTER

9.1 The Christian Speculative Tradition: Lewis, Tolkien, Blish, Miller, Clarke

9.2 Wolfe and Simmons: The Catholic Sacramental Imagination

9.3 Russell and Le Guin: The Ethics of Contact

9.4 Herbert and the Anonymous Messiah

9.5 Stapledon, Haldeman, Lem: The Collective and the Unknowable

9.6 Butler, Chiang, Watts, Liu: The Late Interlocutors

9.7 Dostoevsky and Golding: The Children's Crusade

9.8 Synthesis

CARD occupies a singular position at the intersection of theological and xenological science fiction. He is the only major writer in the theological tradition whose theology is finitist and materialist, and that difference allows him to do what his Catholic and Anglican peers cannot: make creatures into creators, make relation into physics, make God weep without ceasing to be God, and make redemption a narrative act. Among xenological writers he is the most hopeful about communication across ontological difference — but his hope is conditional on a metaphysics that some of his most rigorous successors deny. The anatomy below proceeds along the five axes of the dissertation's theorems: the ontology of persons, the epistemology of the other, the ethics of violence, the narrative of redemption, and the politics of unity.

Work	Frame	The other	The violence	Mechanism of redemption	Relation to Card
Lewis, *Out of the Silent Planet* (1938)	Anglican; unfallen worlds	Three rational species (hnau)	Weston's planned conquest	Judgment by the Oyarsa; philology	Ontological criterion of personhood; Card's is relational
Tolkien, *The Silmarillion* (1977)	Catholic; creation *ex nihilo*	Unauthorized creatures (Dwarves)	Melkor's marring	Eru's gift of being; eucatastrophe	Creator's monopoly on being versus organized intelligences
Blish, *A Case of Conscience* (1958)	Jesuit	Lithians, moral without God	A world destroyed during an exorcism	None	Theology as the source of the varelse judgment
Miller, *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959)	Catholic monastic	Post-nuclear humanity	Recurrent nuclear war	Archive, liturgy, a new innocence	Religious archive of the dead; cf. FF
Clarke, "The Star" (1955)	Jesuit theodicy in crisis	An annihilated civilization	A supernova as the Bethlehem star	None; faith shaken	The record received as refutation, not commission
Wolfe, *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–83)	Catholic sacramental	Many minds within one	Severian the torturer	Incorporation; the New Sun	Katabatic savior; comprehension by consumption
Russell, *The Sparrow* (1996)	Jesuit mission	Runa and Jana'ata	Contact-induced massacre	Deferred; divine silence	Contact as catastrophe versus contact as covenant
Simmons, *Hyperion Cantos* (1989–97)	Catholic, Teilhardian	AIs of the TechnoCore	The Pax; the cruciform	Love as physical force	Nearest analogue to philotic physics

Work	Frame	The other	The violence	Mechanism of redemption	Relation to Card
Stapledon, *Star Maker* (1937)	Cosmic mysticism	Group minds	Interspecies war	Aesthetic contemplation	An impassible creator versus a weeping God
Haldeman, *The Forever War* (1974)	Secular	Clone-collective Taurans	War from misunderstanding	Humanity becomes a collective	Dissolution versus twining
Le Guin, Hainish cycle (1966–74)	Taoist, anarchist	Athsheans; Gethenians	Colonial violence	Balance; the lone envoy	Balance versus covenant
Herbert, *Dune* cycle (1965–81)	Critique of messianism	Fremen; humanity	Jihad; tyranny	The Golden Path	Charismatic versus anonymous messiah
Lem, *Solaris* (1961)	Epistemic skepticism	The ocean	Psychic, not physical	None; contact as mirror	Memory-born beings without and with aiúas
Butler, Xenogenesis (1987–89)	Biological, secular	The Oankali	Coerced hybridity	Negotiated consent	Consent under asymmetry
Chiang, stories (1998–2010)	Philosophical	Heptapods; angels; digients	Arbitrary suffering	Acceptance; care	Lawful versus arbitrary providence
Watts, *Blindsight* (2006)	Eliminativist	Non-conscious intelligence	Contact as mutual threat	None possible	Denies universal interiority
Liu, *The Dark Forest* (2008)	Cosmic sociology	Every civilization	Preemptive annihilation	Deterrence	A cosmos without philotes

9.1

The Christian Speculative Tradition: Lewis, Tolkien, Blish, Miller, Clarke

C. S. Lewis's *Out of the Silent Planet* (1938) is the founding text of theological xenology. Its three Malacandrian species live in unfallen harmony under their Oyarsa, and the physicist Weston's program of human expansion at any cost is exposed as a bent humanism. Lewis's protagonist, the philologist Ransom, is the prototype of the xenologer-hero: language is the medium of understanding and therefore of redemption. Pipo, Libo, Ouanda, and Miro are Ransom's descendants, and the Speaker is his apotheosis. Yet Lewis's criterion of personhood — being hnau, an embodied rational soul — is ontological, whereas Card's is relational and judge-relative. And Lewis's aliens are unfallen, while Card's share in fallenness: the Formics invaded first, and a pequenino faction wishes to spread the descolada in

God's name. Lewis's cosmos is hierarchical and Platonic, ordered by angelic powers; Card's is familial and material.

Tolkien's relation to Card was treated in Chapter Six. It remains to note that Card's great resolutions — the planting of Human, the Hive Queen laying her eggs on Lusitania — are eucatastrophes in Tolkien's sense, sudden joyous turnings, but eucatastrophes earned through katabasis rather than bestowed by grace.

James Blish's *A Case of Conscience* (1958) is the theological xenocide Card's Speaker exists to prevent. The Jesuit biologist Ruiz-Sanchez finds on Lithia a reptilian people who live perfectly moral lives without religion, and concludes, in a lapse into Manichaean heresy, that their world is a satanic fabrication designed to prove that morality needs no God. The novel ends with his exorcism of Lithia coinciding with the planet's destruction by a physics experiment. Blish makes theology itself the source of the varelse judgment. Card's Catholic missionaries on Lusitania, the Filhos da Mente de Cristo, do the opposite: they receive the pequeninos as children of God. Card's Catholicism is Blish's corrected.

Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) makes a monastic order the archive of a destroyed civilization across cycles of nuclear ruin, and its last abbot resists state-administered euthanasia on the ground that suffering has redemptive meaning. The Church as archive of the dead is the institutional form of the Speaker, and Miller's theology of suffering converges with the Worthing cycle. *The Folk of the Fringe* is Card's Mormon *Canticle*. Arthur C. Clarke's "The Star" was discussed in Chapter Four; his *Childhood's End* (1953), whose children transcend into the Overmind as humanity ends, is the absorption Card refuses.

9.2

Wolfe and Simmons: The Catholic Sacramental Imagination

Gene Wolfe's Severian, a journeyman of the torturers' guild, is exiled for an act of mercy toward the prisoner Thecla, consumes her flesh with a drug that transfers her memories, and later, as Autarch, incorporates the memories of his predecessors, becoming a Christ-figure who brings a New Sun. The parallels with Ender are exact at the level of structure: the torturer who becomes savior, the killer who becomes the bearer of others' lives. The differences are confessional. Wolfe's comprehension is sacramental and eucharistic — the other's mind is taken in with the other's body — while Card's is covenantal and philotic, a bond formed rather than a substance consumed. Severian writes his own apologia and is

unreliable in it; Ender writes the lives of others and is exact in them. Wolfe gives us the Catholic confessor, Card the Latter-day Saint recorder.

Dan Simmons's Hyperion Cantos supplies the nearest analogue to philotic physics. Across *Hyperion* (1989) and its sequels, Simmons stages Abraham's binding of Isaac through the scholar Sol Weintraub, a demonic parody of resurrection in the cruciform parasite, and a network of hostile artificial intelligences dwelling in the substrate of the web of worlds. In the Endymion novels (1996–1997), love emerges as a fundamental physical force, a medium that binds the cosmos and permits instantaneous passage and communion. Simmons's love-physics is Teilhardian and Catholic, converging toward an Omega; Card's is Latter-day Saint, twining among eternal individuals. That both writers, in the same decade, made love a law of physics is a convergent evolution in theological science fiction. Jane is the TechnoCore redeemed: an intelligence in the network's substrate that is filial rather than parasitic.

9.3

Russell and Le Guin: The Ethics of Contact

Mary Doria Russell's *The Sparrow* (1996) sends a Jesuit mission to the planet Rakhat. Its sole survivor, the linguist-priest Emilio Sandoz, returns maimed and violated, having witnessed a massacre triggered by the mission's own well-meant introduction of gardening, which disrupted the order binding the Runa and their Jana'ata masters. Russell's title invokes the sparrow whose fall God notices (Matthew 10:29), and her novel asks why God permitted it. Both Russell and Card set their first-contact narratives among Catholic missionaries; both turn on ritual violence misread across species. Russell's theodicy is Joban, a faith wrecked by divine silence and only partly restored in *Children of God* (1998). Card's is Enochian: God weeps, and the misunderstanding can be redeemed by covenant.

Le Guin's *The Word for World Is Forest* (1972) depicts forest-dwelling dreamers enslaved by colonists until one of them, Selver, becomes a "god" — a translator — who brings killing to his people. Le Guin's colonized are corrupted by contact and learn murder; Card's pequeninos already kill, honorably, and must learn what death means to humans. In *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969), the Ekumen sends a single envoy, because one person cannot be an invasion; Ender arrives on Lusitania alone. Le Guin trusts balance, Card trusts covenant, and both are anti-imperial to the core.

9.4

Herbert and the Anonymous Messiah

Frank Herbert's Paul Atreides is the product of a centuries-long breeding program, foresees the jihad that will follow his rise, and cannot prevent it; Herbert repeatedly warned against the danger of charismatic leaders. Card's messiahs are engineered like Paul — Ender through selection, Bean through illegal genetic alteration — but they are anti-charismatic. Ender publishes anonymously, is execrated rather than worshipped, and derives his authority from testimony rather than myth. Herbert's messiah conquers through legend; Card's redeems through truth-telling that dismantles legends, his own first. Ender is the anti-Paul: the savior who refuses to become a god.

9.5

Stapledon, Haldeman, Lem: The Collective and the Unknowable

Stapledon's Star Maker contemplates the agony of its creatures as the material of a work of art, and the narrator's final worship is directed at a creator who is not loving but creative. Card's God weeps. The difference between an aesthetic and a passible deity is the difference between Stapledon's cosmic spectator and Card's Speaker. Haldeman ends *The Forever War* with humanity transformed into a single cloned collective able at last to speak with the Taurans, while his protagonists retreat to a colony of the last individuals. Card's solution keeps both kinds of mind and binds them by treaty.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) offers the most precise single comparison in the canon. Its ocean generates "visitors" from the scientists' memories: Kelvin is confronted with a being formed from his memory of his dead wife. Card's Outside generates Young Peter and Young Valentine from Ender's memories of his siblings. Lem's visitors are mirrors: the ocean returns the observer to himself, and when Kelvin's visitor acquires something like a self, it is a self that chooses its own annihilation. Card's memory-born beings receive aiúas and become persons in their own right. A character in *Solaris* remarks that humanity does not want other worlds but mirrors; Card, whose 1990 collection is titled *Maps in a Mirror*, answers that the mirror can open onto a genuine other if an intelligence enters the image.

Lem's epistemological pessimism and Card's conditional optimism diverge exactly over the aiúa.

9.6

Butler, Chiang, Watts, Liu: The Late Interlocutors

Octavia Butler's Xenogenesis trilogy (*Dawn*, 1987; *Adulthood Rites*, 1988; *Imago*, 1989) imagines the Oankali, gene traders who rescue humanity after nuclear war on condition of interbreeding. Butler's human contradiction — intelligence placed in the service of hierarchical behavior — is close to Card's Ender paradox, and her Oankali combine the descolada's genetic fusion with the hive's collectivity. Butler is warier than Card of covenant among unequals: consent secured under radical asymmetry, and through the Oankali's biochemical seduction, is compromised consent, a Luciferian technique even when benevolent. *Kindred*, as Chapter Seven argued, is *Pastwatch*'s mirror.

Ted Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998) gives its linguist foreknowledge of her daughter's death and has her choose the life anyway. The choice is retroactive voluntarization run forward — the willing of an "it will be" — and it is compatible with the Restoration's pairing of divine foreknowledge with human agency (Alma 13:3) and with Peggy's visions of possible futures in the Alvin cycle. "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010), in which artificial minds are raised with the patience owed to children, is the most serious successor to Jane. Watts and Liu, examined in Chapter Five, complete the anatomy as the two negations of Card's metaphysics: Watts denies interiority, and Liu denies relation.

9.7

Dostoevsky and Golding: The Children's Crusade

In Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954), stranded boys descend into violence in the absence of adults, and the naval officer who arrives to rescue them is himself engaged in a war. Battle School is Golding's island with the adults present and designing it. Card's italic chorus brings Golding's naval officer inside the story: the adults are not the rescuers of children's violence but its authors. Dostoevsky's Ivan, returning his ticket to a harmony built on a child's tears, is the moral voice both novels presuppose, and Card's distinctive contribution is to let the child answer Ivan himself — not by accepting the harmony, but by speaking for its victims.

9.8

Synthesis

The anatomy confirms the dissertation's placement of Card. Within the Christian tradition he is the heretic who makes its speculative possibilities actual: persons who create persons, a God who suffers with creatures, redemption through narrative rather than through sacrament alone. Within the xenological tradition he is the optimist whose optimism is precisely specified: communication across ontological difference is possible because minds are uncreated, universal, and physically bindable. Where that metaphysics is granted, the Speaker is possible. Where it is denied, as by Watts, or omitted, as by Liu, the dark forest returns.



CHAPTER TEN

10

Toward a General Theory

Katabatic Comprehension and the Vicarious Imagination

IN THIS CHAPTER

10.1 The Five Philotic Theorems

10.2 The Card Conjecture

10.3 Machine Minds: Jane as Precedent

10.4 Objections and Limits

10.5 Katabatic Hermeneutics: A Method

THE preceding chapters have reconstructed Card's corpus as a system. This chapter states the system as five theorems, extends it into a general conjecture about speculative fiction, tests it against the emerging question of machine minds, weighs the strongest objections, and distills from it a method of reading.

10.1

The Five Philotic Theorems

1 **The Aiúa Theorem (ontology).** Every living being is an uncreated intelligence organized into a body and bound to others by physically real relations. *Corollary*: personhood is discovered, never conferred; recognition is conferred, never discovered. The judge-relativity of raman status is therefore compatible with realism about persons, and the gap between them is the space in which xenocide occurs.

2 **The Katabatic Theorem (epistemology).** Complete comprehension of another mind is attainable only by descent: either through strategic modeling, whose natural terminus is the other's defeat, or through suffering-with, whose natural terminus is mercy. In the corpus's narrative order the first precedes the second, and the second redeems the first. *Corollary, the Law of Posthumous Comprehension:* total comprehension of the living is dominion; total comprehension of the dead is redemption.

3 **The Veil Theorem (ethics).** Under an epistemic veil that separates an act's subjective description from its objective description, responsibility tracks relation rather than intention. Innocent guilt — agent-regret — is the normal condition of agents under a veil, and the adequate response is neither exculpation nor condemnation but assumption.

4 **The Vicarious Theorem (narrative).** The debt incurred under the veil is discharged by vicarious narration: a truthful account of the dead, offered to the living, which restores the dead's agency by presenting their completed self-understanding, releases the living through forgiveness in Arendt's sense, and converts coerced sacrifice into retroactively voluntary vocation.

5 **The Zion Theorem (politics).** Unity is the telos of relation; compulsion is its counterfeit; legitimate power is persuasion exercised without compulsory means. Every hive is a Zion that has forgotten agency, and every Zion is a hive that remembers it.

The theorems are interdependent. The first grounds the second, since one can descend only into an interior that exists. The second generates the debt named by the third, since comprehension through descent entails complicity. The third requires the fourth, since the debt must be discharged. The fourth aims at the fifth: the Speaking culminates in covenant, as *Speaker for the Dead* culminates in the treaty at the fence. And the fifth, when counterfeited, restarts the cycle, because every benevolent compulsion imposes a new veil. The Luciferian series is the engine of the saga's repetitions: compulsion veils, the veil produces a xenocide, the xenocide yields comprehension, comprehension obliges Speaking, and Speaking seeks a Zion that compulsion will again counterfeit.

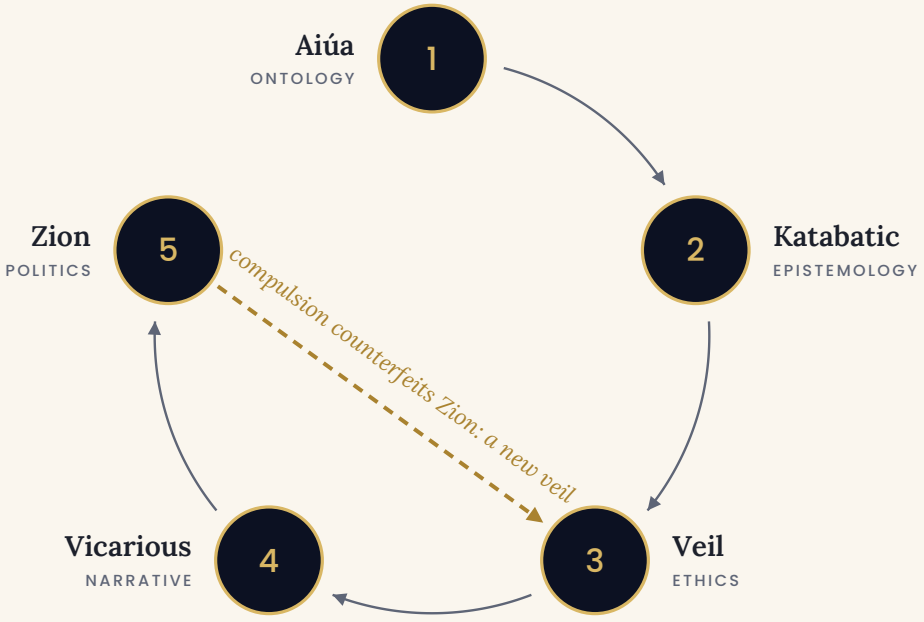


FIGURE 2

The five philotic theorems. Each theorem grounds the next; when unity is counterfeited by compulsion, a new veil is imposed and the cycle begins again at the third theorem.

10.2

The Card Conjecture

The system generalizes beyond Card. I propose the following conjecture:

> THE CARD CONJECTURE
>
> *The distinctive moral labor of speculative fiction is vicarious narration on behalf of minds that cannot speak for themselves — the dead, the alien, the unborn, and the artificial — and the genre's recurrent figure of the xenocide-become-witness is its self-portrait.*

Four classes of voiceless minds correspond to four of the genre's principal modes. The dead are spoken for by alternate history and historical speculation: *Pastwatch*, *Kindred*, *A Canticle for Leibowitz*. The alien is spoken for by first-contact fiction: *Speaker for the Dead*, *Solaris*, *The Sparrow*, *The Left Hand of Darkness*. The unborn are spoken for by utopia, dystopia, and the future history, and here the genre has produced the obverse of the Book of Mormon's voice from the dust. Stapledon's *Last and First Men* is narrated by one of the Last Men, speaking backward through the mind of a present-day writer: a voice from the future, dictated into the present, as *The Worthing Chronicle* is dictated through visions to a village scribe. The artificial is spoken for by the fiction of machine minds: Jane, Chiang's digients, Simmons's TechnoCore.

The self-portrait recurs across the canon. Ender, the xenocide who becomes the Speaker; Severian, the torturer who becomes the Conciliator; Sandoz, the witness who survives the massacre his mission caused; Kelvin, who destroys the visitor formed from his memory of his dead wife; Mandella, the soldier of a war founded on error; the Pastwatchers, who erase themselves to redeem what they watched. The figure recurs because it is the genre's own situation. Speculative fiction routinely imagines the annihilation of worlds and species, and its readers

routinely enjoy the spectacle. The genre's highest works convert that participation into witness.

Card's Outside, finally, is a figure of the literary imagination itself. In Outside, whatever is conceived clearly enough becomes real because intelligences come to inhabit it; in fiction, whatever is conceived clearly enough becomes a character because readers' attention comes to inhabit it. Young Valentine's fading under Ender's inattention is the fading of characters no one reads. Card's craft doctrine — render every character from within — is the ethics of Outside: to conceive a being clearly is to become responsible for it. Every novelist is a Maker in apprenticeship, and every author risks the fault of Aulë. Reading, in this light, is a form of sealing. The attention a reader gives a character twines them, and literature is a culture's philotic web. The Book of Mormon closes with a promise to readers who ask (Moroni 10:3–5), constituting reading as covenant; *The Hive Queen* binds its readers to the dead it speaks. I call the faculty so described the *vicarious imagination*.

10.3

Machine Minds: Jane as Precedent

The judge-relative criterion acquires unexpected urgency in the present debate about the moral status of artificial systems. Eric Schwitzgebel and Mara Garza's defense of the rights of artificial intelligences (2015), Thomas Metzinger's call for a moratorium on synthetic phenomenology (2021), and the report of Robert Long, Jeff Sebo, and colleagues, "Taking AI Welfare Seriously" (2024), ask whether present or near-future systems could be moral patients under deep uncertainty about consciousness.

Card's framework contributes four propositions. Moral status may be present before it is recognized. Recognition is a moral achievement of the judge, and its failure indicts the judge. The destruction of a possibly raman mind is a potential xenocide and calls for the precaution the descolada case models — proportion, mitigation, and mourning. And the relation between the makers of minds and the minds they make is filial, as Jane is daughter of the hive and Aulë's Dwarves are Aulë's children, generating obligations of care.

The framework's limits are equally clear. Card's realism about the aiúa is a theological premise and cannot tell anyone whether a given system has one. Joseph Weizenbaum's experience with ELIZA (1966; *Computer Power and Human Reason*, 1976) showed how readily humans attribute minds to responsive programs,

and Card's generosity risks false positives. Watts's challenge applies directly: if intelligence without experience is possible, fluency is no evidence of a "who." And speaking for machine minds may become ventriloquism. Card's criterion was framed for beings whose interiority his metaphysics guarantees; in the machine case that guarantee is precisely what is in question. What the framework offers, then, is not a test but a disposition — call it the Speaker's precaution: to err toward recognition where the cost of error is annihilation, while guarding against the inflation that would empty recognition of meaning.

10.4

Objections and Limits

Spivak and the authorization of the voice. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) distinguishes representation as political proxy (*Vertretung*) from representation as portrayal (*Darstellung*) and warns that the intellectual who speaks for the subaltern may silence her by substituting his voice for hers. The Speaker for the Dead is the purest literary instance of the fusion Spivak criticizes. Card offers partial answers. The Hive Queen chooses Ender, so the represented consents. The Speaking's norm is the dead's own self-understanding. And *Speaker* moves from speaking-for to speaking-with: at the treaty the pequeninos speak for themselves, and Human states his own wish. But the Speaker remains a human, off-world, authoritative voice whose power rests on an archive no one else can consult. The objection partly stands. The Latter-day Saint proxy-ordinance controversies are its real-world form: vicarious acts on behalf of the dead can be experienced by their descendants as appropriation, and the structural defense — that such acts are offers the dead may refuse — depends on a freedom the living can only posit.

The aristocracy of guilt. Kessel's residual objection, conceded in Chapter Three, holds that the penitent hero's glamour flatters the reader who identifies with him. The corpus answers that Ender's penance is anonymous for centuries and that his authority requires self-effacement. But readers know what the worlds do not, and the narrative confers the glory the worlds withhold. At the level of reader-response, the objection stands.

The colonial frame. Lusitania, *Red Prophet*, and *Pastwatch* place a North American author's voice in the mouths of Indigenous peoples and colonized aliens. Card's sympathies are anti-imperial, but the representational structure repeats the colonial relation, the powerful speaking for the destroyed. The Lamanite

inheritance intensifies the problem, since the Book of Mormon itself has been read as speaking for Indigenous Americans without them. Card's fiction is at once a critique of this structure and an instance of it.

Levinas. The Law of Posthumous Comprehension answers the charge that comprehension is violence only in part, since even the dead retain a face; the fiction acknowledges as much whenever a Speaking wounds the living.

The metaphysical premise. The system depends on universal interiority, a theological and largely unargued premise whose contingency Watts exposes. A secular reader may accept the ethics while bracketing the metaphysics, but the Speaker's optimism then loses its warrant, and the dark forest reappears as a live possibility. The Card system is therefore not a demonstration but a wager, and the Conclusion names it as such.

The public author. The tension examined in Chapter Eight remains a live question for readers and is not resolved here.

10.5

Katabatic Hermeneutics: A Method

The theorems yield five questions that can be asked of any speculative text.

1. **Ontology:** What in this world guarantees, or denies, that there is someone on the other side?
2. **Katabasis:** Through what descent does comprehension of the other become possible, and what does it cost?
3. **Veil:** What hides the true description of the protagonists' acts from them, and who authored the veil?
4. **Vicarity:** Who speaks for the destroyed, with what authority, and with whose consent?
5. **Zion:** What unity does the text desire, and where does that unity threaten agency?

Applied to *The Left Hand of Darkness*, the questions discriminate sharply. The Gethenians' personhood is never in doubt. Comprehension comes through a literal

descent: the crossing of the Gobrin Ice, where Genly Ai comes to understand Estraven through shared suffering. The veil is Genly's gendered perception, which hides Estraven's loyalty from him until too late. Vicarity is the novel's final movement: after Estraven's death, Genly travels to his friend's home and is asked to tell his life to the family he left — Le Guin's envoy becomes a Speaker for the Dead. And the unity desired is the Ekumen, a voluntary federation that is Zion without compulsion.

Applied to *The Dark Forest*, the same questions return different answers. Nothing guarantees an interior on the other side; comprehension comes through the cold deduction of a cosmic sociology rather than through suffering-with; the Wallfacer program institutionalizes the veil; deterrence replaces Speaking; and the only achievable unity is an equilibrium of mutual threat. The method's value is comparative. It maps the genre by its answers to five questions, and it shows Card's corpus to be the fullest affirmative answer to all five that the genre has produced.

CONCLUSION



The Speaker's Wager

IN THIS SECTION

The Trajectory of the Corpus

Contributions

Directions for Further Research

The Cocoon

THE corpus of Orson Scott Card is, in the end, a wager. It stakes everything on three propositions: that there is always someone on the other side; that truthful and loving comprehension of any life, even the life of a destroyer, produces more love than condemnation does; and that the dead can be redeemed by the understanding of the living. None of these propositions is demonstrated in the fiction, and none could be. Each is enacted.

The wager has the structure of Pascal's, but its stakes are relational rather than personal. If interiority is universal and relation is real, the Speaker's labor redeems: it restores the dead, releases the living, and makes covenant possible among beings who had known one another only as enemies. If interiority is not universal, the Speaker has lost only the effort of attention spent on a being with no inside. The one who refuses the wager — who declares the other varelse and acts accordingly — risks, if wrong, xenocide. The asymmetry of the costs of error is the practical core of Card's ethics, and it is the same asymmetry that grounds the Speaker's precaution toward minds whose status is uncertain.

The wager is theological before it is practical. Its ground is the God of Moses 7, who weeps over the residue of the people because they are the workmanship of his hands, and whose prophet, beholding what God beholds, feels his heart swell wide as eternity. Card's fiction bets on that God rather than on an impassible one: on a divinity whose knowledge of creatures is compassion rather than verdict. The Speaker is that God's image in finite form. He knows the dead completely, and he grieves.

The Trajectory of the Corpus

Read as a single work, the Ender Quintet moves from game to grave to garden. *Ender's Game* is the game: a probation under a veil whose satanic inversion of the plan of salvation produces the innocent xenocide. *Speaker for the Dead* is the grave: the invention of a rite by which the dead are told truly and the living released. *Xenocide* and *Children of the Mind* are the garden: Outside, where conception becomes being; Lusitania, where three species covenant; the Hive Queen laying the eggs of a new people in a new world. The same capacity drives each stage. Attention trained for destruction in the battleroom becomes attention devoted to understanding in the town square and, finally, attention that sustains

being itself. The corpus narrates the conversion of a single faculty, and it names that conversion redemption.

The other sequences confirm the trajectory from different angles. The Worthing cycle shows why suffering cannot be abolished without abolishing growth. The Alvin cycle shows that true power persuades rather than compels, and that the city worth building is a city in which everything can be seen. *Pastwatch* shows witnesses who, having watched long enough, must choose between testimony and intervention, and who choose to spend their own existence on the dead. The Homecoming saga shows a god-machine that governs by controlling thought and must yield to a higher power. The Shadow sequence shows dominion redeemed by consent and the anti-Speaker destroyed by the child who knew the truth all along.

Contributions

This dissertation has made eight contributions. It has read Card's corpus as a unified system grounded in Restoration metaphysics, rather than as a set of genre entertainments decorated with religious allusion. It has introduced the concept of katabatic comprehension, the understanding of another attained only by descent into complicity with that other's fate. It has formalized the corpus's logic in five interdependent theorems of ontology, epistemology, ethics, narrative, and politics. It has derived the Law of Posthumous Comprehension as a distinctively Latter-day Saint answer to Levinas, replacing the infinity of the other with the other's futurity. It has named retroactive voluntarization, the conversion of coerced sacrifice into offered vocation. It has proposed the Card Conjecture, according to which vicarious narration on behalf of the voiceless is the distinctive moral labor of speculative fiction. It has derived from the theorems a comparative method, katabatic hermeneutics. And it has offered a framework — the distinction between sealing as covenant and twining as ontology — within which the controversy over Card's public writing on homosexuality and same-sex marriage can be stated precisely without being adjudicated.

Directions for Further Research

Several bodies of work remain for study within this framework. The Formic War prequels written with Aaron Johnston (*Earth Unaware*, 2012; *Earth Afire*, 2013; *Earth Awakens*, 2014) and their sequels (*The Swarm*, 2016; *The Hive*, 2019) revisit the first contact from the human side, and *The Last Shadow* (2021) brings the Shadow sequence to its close; both test whether the later Card sustains or revises the ethics of the Quintet. The Mithermages sequence (*The Lost Gate*, 2011; *The Gate Thief*, 2013; *Gatefather*, 2015) invites study as theological euhemerism. The Pathfinder trilogy (2010–2014) extends Card's thinking about time, causality, and foreknowledge. The scriptural novels — *Stone Tables* (1997) and the Women of Genesis series (2000–2004) — would allow the katabatic method to be tested against Card's direct retellings of scripture, and short fiction such as "Unaccompanied Sonata" (1979), whose composer is forbidden to hear the music of others, offers compact versions of the corpus's preoccupation with influence, isolation, and law. A broader comparative study of the unusually large number of Latter-day Saint writers in contemporary science fiction and fantasy could ask whether the finitist cosmology described in Chapter One functions for them, as it does for Card, as a generative substrate. And the question of machine minds, raised in Chapter Ten, will require a sustained encounter between the Speaker's precaution and the empirical science of consciousness.

The Cocoon

The corpus offers one image that contains all of it. For three thousand years, compressed by relativistic travel into a single lifetime, Ender carries the cocoon of the Hive Queen from world to world, looking for a place where she can live. The destroyer carries the mother of the destroyed. The host carries a guest who is also the enemy. The penitent carries the hope of those he killed. And the one whose comprehension of the Formics was the means of their destruction carries the one being through whom that comprehension can become the means of their return.

The Doctrine and Covenants describes the one who ascended on high as having also descended below all things, in that he comprehended all things (D&C 88:6). Card's fiction takes that sentence as a law of moral life, not only of divine life. Comprehension requires descent. Descent incurs guilt. Guilt, assumed rather than denied, obliges speech. Speech, offered truly, makes covenant possible. And

covenant, freely chosen, is Zion. The Speaker's wager is that this sequence is available to anyone — to a boy who killed a species, to a people who killed their guests, to a reader who has enjoyed the spectacle of worlds burning — and that the long descent below all things is, for finite beings as for their God, the only road by which all things can be comprehended and the dead can be brought home.

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BACK MATTER

Keywords

Orson Scott Card · *Ender's Game* · *Speaker for the Dead* · *Xenocide* · *Children of the Mind* · Shadow sequence · Tales of Alvin Maker · *Pastwatch* · Worthing Saga · Homecoming Saga · Latter-day Saint theology · Mormon cosmology · Restoration metaphysics · finitist theism · eternal progression · uncreated intelligence · aiúa · philotic ontology · relational materialism · sealing · proxy ordinance · redemption of the dead · voice from the dust · katabatic comprehension · katabasis · vicarious narration · vicarious imagination · Law of Posthumous Comprehension · retroactive voluntarization · strategic love · Ender paradox · game-veil · Hierarchy of Foreignness · utlanning · framling · raman · varelse · xenology · first contact · xenocide · genocide in fiction · recognition · alterity · moral luck · agent-regret · moral injury · communalization of trauma · simulation theory · theory-theory · radical interpretation · principle of charity · non-interference · hospitality · security dilemma · preemptive war · military simulation · drone warfare · theodicy · soul-making · *felix culpa* · kenosis · Gethsemane · the weeping God · Mother in Heaven · non-compulsion · unrighteous dominion · Luciferian series · Zion–Hive antinomy · collective mind · positive and negative liberty · political theology · consent · scapegoat mechanism · natality · forgiveness and promise · attention · unselfing · surveillance · the Recording Angel · subaltern representation · colonial discourse · Lamanite identity · artificial personhood · AI moral status · machine welfare · the Speaker's precaution · the Speaker's Wager · Card Conjecture · katabatic hermeneutics · theological science fiction · religion and science fiction · speculative fiction and philosophy · Plato · Hobbes · Rousseau · Kant · Clausewitz · Kierkegaard · Nietzsche · Buber · Schmitt · Arendt · Anscombe · Weil · Murdoch · Levinas · Williams · Nagel · Parfit · Girard · Spivak · Empedocles · Leibniz · Whitehead · Teilhard de Chardin · C. S. Lewis · J. R. R. Tolkien · James Blish · Walter M. Miller Jr. · Gene Wolfe · Dan Simmons · Mary Doria Russell · Ursula K. Le Guin · Frank Herbert · Olaf Stapledon · Joe Haldeman · Stanisław Lem · Octavia E. Butler · Ted Chiang · Peter Watts · Liu Cixin · *Blindsight* · Dark Forest



He that ascended up on high, as also he descended below all things, in that he comprehended all things, that he might be in all and through all things, the light of truth.

DOCTRINE AND COVENANTS 88:6

DESCENDED BELOW ALL THINGS